



Anthropology

Course Code: Anth101

Credit Hours: 3

Unit One

Introducing Anthropology and its Subject Matter

Definition, Scope and Subject Matter of Anthropology

Anthropology is the study of people their origins, their development, and contemporary variations, wherever and whenever they have been found. It is a broad scientific discipline dedicated to the comparative study of humans as a group, from its first appearance on earth to its present stage of development. Of all the disciplines that study humans, anthropology is by far the broadest in scope.

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In more specific terms, anthropology is a science which:

Investigates the strategies for living that are learned and shared by people as members of human social groups;

Examines the characteristics that human beings share as members of one species (*homo sapiens*) and the diverse ways that people live in different environments;

Analyses the products of social groups -material objects (material cultures) and non-material creations (religion/beliefs, social values, institutions, practices, etc).

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- Anthropology is an intellectually challenging, theoretically ambitious subject, which tries to achieve an understanding of culture, society and humanity through detailed studies of community life, supplemented by comparison. At the deepest level, it raises philosophical questions, which it tries to respond to by exploring human lives under different conditions. It seeks to explain how and why people are both similar and different through examination of our biological and cultural past and comparative study of contemporary human societies. Its ultimate goal is **to develop an integrated picture of humankind** a goal that encompasses an almost infinite number of questions about all aspects of our existence. We ask, for example, what makes us human? Why do some groups of people tend to be tall and lanky, while others tend to be short and stocky? Why do some groups of people practice agriculture, while others hunt for a living?

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- As a matter of simplicity and brevity, anthropology primarily offers two kinds of insight.
- First, the discipline ***produces knowledge*** about the actual biological and cultural variations in the world;
- Second, anthropology offers **methods and theoretical** perspectives enabling the practitioner to explore, compare, understand and solve these varied expressions of the human condition.

Scope and subject matter of anthropology

The breadth and depth of anthropology is immense. There no time and space left as far as man exists. In other words, the temporal dimension covers the past, the present and even the future. In terms of the spatial dimension, anthropology studies from Arctic to Desert, from Megapolis to hunting gathering areas. The discipline covers all aspects of human ways of life experiences and existence, as humans live in a social group.

It touches all *aspect of human* conditions as far as there is a relation between human beings and natural environment and man and man. Anthropology not only tries to account for the social and cultural variation in the world, but a crucial part of the anthropological project also consists in conceptualizing and understanding similarities between social systems and human relationships.

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- As one of the foremost anthropologists of the twentieth century, Claude Lévi-Strauss, has expressed it: *'Anthropology has humanity as its object of research, but unlike the other human sciences, it tries to grasp its object through its most diverse manifestations'*. In other words, *anthropology studies humanity with its all aspects of existence, and in its all means of differences (diversity) and similarities (commonality)*. **Where every human being lives, there is always anthropology.**
- The discipline is also accounting for the interrelationships between different aspects of human existence, and usually anthropologists investigate these interrelationships taking as their point of departure a detailed study of local life in a particular society or a delineated social environment.

Sub-fields of anthropology

- **Physical/Biological Anthropology**
- Deals with tracing the biological origins, evolutionary changes and the genetic diversity of the human species.
- **Physical** anthropology is the branch of anthropology most closely related to the natural sciences, particularly biology; that is why it is often called biological anthropology. Human biology affects or even explains some aspects of behavior, society, and culture like marriage patterns, sexual division of labor, gender ideology etc. The features of culture in turn have biological effects like the standards of attractiveness, food preferences, and human sexuality.

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- Physical anthropology is essentially concerned with two broad areas of investigation: **human evolution and genetics**.
- **Human evolution** is the study of the gradual processes of simple forms into more differentiated structures in hominid. It is interested in reconstructing the evolutionary record of the human species using fossils/bones. Human evolution is further divided into two specialties: Paleoanthropology and Primatology.
- Palaeoanthropology (paleo meaning “old”) is the study of human biological evolution through the analysis of fossil remains from prehistoric times to determine the missing link that connect modern human with its biological ancestors.
- Primatology studies about primates or recent human ancestors to explain human evolution. Primatologists study the anatomy and social behavior of such non-human primate species as gorillas and chimpanzees in an effort to gain clues about our own evolution as a species.

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- **Human genetics** concerns to investigate how and why the physical traits of contemporary human populations vary throughout the world. It focuses to examine the genetic materials of an organism such as DNA and RNA. In addition, genetic studies are crucial in understanding – how evolution works and plays important role in identifying the genetic source of some hereditary disease like sickle cell anemia and cystic fibrosis.

Archaeological Anthropology

- Archaeological anthropology or simply archaeology studies the ways of lives of past peoples by excavating and analyzing the material culture/physical remains (**artifacts, features and eco-facts**) they left behind.
- **Artifacts** are material remains made and used by the past peoples and that can be removed from the site and taken to the laboratory for further analysis. Tools, ornaments, arrowheads, coins, and fragments of pottery are examples of artifacts.
- **Features** are like artifacts, are made or modified by past people, but they cannot be readily carried away from the site. Archaeological features include such things as house foundations, ancient buildings, fireplaces, steles, and postholes.
- **Eco-facts** are non-artifactual, organic and environmental remains such as soil, animal bones, and plant remains that were not made or altered by humans; but were used by them. Eco-facts provide archaeologists with important data concerning the environment and how people used natural resources in the past.

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- Archaeology has also its own subfields or areas of specialties. The most important ones are -*Prehistoric Archaeology and Historical Archaeology*.
- Prehistoric archaeology investigates human prehistory and prehistoric cultures. It focuses on entire period between 6,000 years ago and the time of the first stone tools (the first artifacts), around 2.5 million years ago, is called prehistory.
- Historic archaeologists help to reconstruct the cultures of people who used writing and about whom historical documents have been written. Historic archaeology takes advantage of the fact that about 6,000 years ago, some human groups invented language and began to write down things that can tell about the past.
- We Ethiopian have very glorious past. Area logical findings in North, south, east and western part of the country have shown our county belonged to those countries which have old civilization.

Linguistic Anthropology

- Linguistic anthropology or anthropological linguistics studies human language as a cultural resource and speaking as a cultural practice in its social and cultural context, across space and time. **Language** is basically a system of information transmission and reception. Humans communicate messages by sound (speech), by gesture (body language), and in other visual ways such as writing. Analogous to genes that carry and transmit genetic materials to offspring, languages hand down cultural traits from one generation to another. In fact, some would argue that language is the most distinctive feature of being human. Although animals could develop certain behaviors through conditioning that mimic to humans, they do not have a capacity to pass on their own offspring. This is the boundary between human beings and other animals including higher primates.

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- Linguistic anthropology, which studies contemporary human languages as well as those of the past, is divided into four distinct branches or areas of research: *Structural or Descriptive Linguistics*, *Historical Linguistics*, *Ethno-Linguistics*, and *Socio-linguistics*.
- **Structural /Descriptive Linguistics:** -studies the structure of linguistic patterns. It examines sound systems, grammatical systems, and the meanings attached to words in specific languages to understand the structure and set of rules of given language. Every culture has a distinctive language with its own logical structure and set of rules for putting words and sounds together for the purpose of communicating. In its simplest form, the task of the descriptive linguist is to compile dictionaries and grammar books for previously unwritten languages. For structuralist linguist or structural linguistic anthropologist, even if there are thousands of human languages, at least structurally all of them are similar making it possible for everyone of us to grasp and learn languages other than our so called 'mother tongue'.

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- **Ethno-linguistics (cultural linguistics):** examines the relationship between language and culture. In any language, certain cultural aspects that are emphasized (such as types of snow among the Inuit, cows among the pastoral Maasai, or automobiles in U.S. culture) are reflected in the vocabulary. Moreover, cultural linguists explore how different linguistic categories can affect how people categorize their experiences, how they think, and how they perceive the world around them.
- **Historical linguistics:** - deals with the emergence of language in general and how specific languages have diverged over time. It focuses on the comparison and classifications of different languages to differentiate the historical links between them.

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- ***Socio-linguistics***: -investigates linguistic variation within a given language. No language is a homogeneous system in which everyone speaks just like everyone else. One reason for variation is geography, as in regional dialects and accents. Linguistic variation also is expressed in the bilingualism of ethnic groups.
- Linguistic anthropology generally focuses on the evolution of languages. It tries to understand languages variation in their structures, units, and grammatical formations. It gives special attention to the study of unwritten languages. Language is a key to explore a culture.

Socio-Cultural Anthropology

- It is also often called **social anthropology** or **cultural anthropology**. Socio-cultural anthropology is the largest sub-fields of anthropology. It deals with human society and culture. Society is the group of people who have similar ways of life, but culture is a way of life of a group of people. Society and culture are two sides of the same coin. Socio-cultural anthropology describes, analyzes, interprets, and explains social, cultural and material life of contemporary human societies. It studies the social (human relations), symbolic or nonmaterial (religious, language, and any other symbols) and material (all man-made objects) lives of living peoples.

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- Socio-cultural anthropologists engage in two aspects of study: Ethnography (based on field work) and Ethnology (based on cross-cultural comparison).
- **Ethnography** provides a comprehensive account of a particular community, society, or culture. It describes the features of specific cultures in as much detail as possible including local behavior, beliefs, customs, social life, economic activities, politics, and religion. These detailed descriptions (ethnographies) are the result of extensive field studies (usually a year or two, in duration) in which the anthropologist observes, talks to, and lives with the people he or she is studying. During ethnographic fieldwork, the anthropologist (ethnographer) gathers data that he or she organizes, describes, analyzes, and interprets to build and present that account, which may be in the form of a book, article, or film.

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- **Ethnology** is the comparative study of contemporary cultures and societies, wherever they may be found. It examines, interprets, analyzes, and compares the results of ethnography the data gathered in different societies. It uses such data to compare and contrast and to make generalizations about society and culture. In other words, Ethnologists seek to understand both why people today and in the recent past differ in terms of ideas and behavior patterns and what all cultures in the world have in common with one another. Looking beyond the particular to the more general, ethnologists attempt to identify and explain cultural differences and similarities, to test hypotheses, and to build theory to enhance our understanding of how social and cultural systems work. Indeed, the primary objective of ethnology is to uncover general cultural principles, the “rules” that govern human behavior.

Unique (Basic) Features of Anthropology

- Anthropology is unique in its **scope**, **approach**, **focus** and **method of study**.
- Anthropology has a broad scope. It is interested in all human beings, whether contemporary or past, "primitive" or "civilized" and that they are interested in many different aspects of humans, including their phenotypic characteristics, family lives, marriages, political systems, economic lives, technology, belief, health care systems, personality types, and languages. No place or time is too remote to escape the anthropologist's notice.
- In its approach anthropology is holistic, relativistic, and focused one. Holistic in a sense that it looks any phenomena from different vantage points. Accordingly, anthropology considers culture, history, language and biology essential to a complete understanding of society. Anthropology seeks to understand human beings as whole organisms who adapt to their environments through a complex interaction of biology and culture.

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- Anthropology's comparative perspective helps to understand differences and similarities across time and place. Another important perspective is a way of looking at people's ideas. It considers insiders' views as a primary focus of any anthropological inquiry. Anthropological studies give attention to how people perceive themselves and understand their world; how a particular group of people explain about their action, or give meaning to their behavior or cultural practices.

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- Another important unique feature is its research approach. Anthropology is highly dependent on qualitative research to understand the meaning behind any human activity. Extended fieldwork, participant observation, in-depth and key informant interviews and focus-group discussion are qualitative research instruments to explore information change and continuities in human societies. Ethnographic fieldwork is an important strategy is normally required to spend a year or more with research subjects and document realities occurring across time. For most anthropologists, fieldwork is a process requiring them to ‘tune-in; hangout; and hang-on’ to the societies and cultures whom they are interested to study.

Misconceptions about anthropology

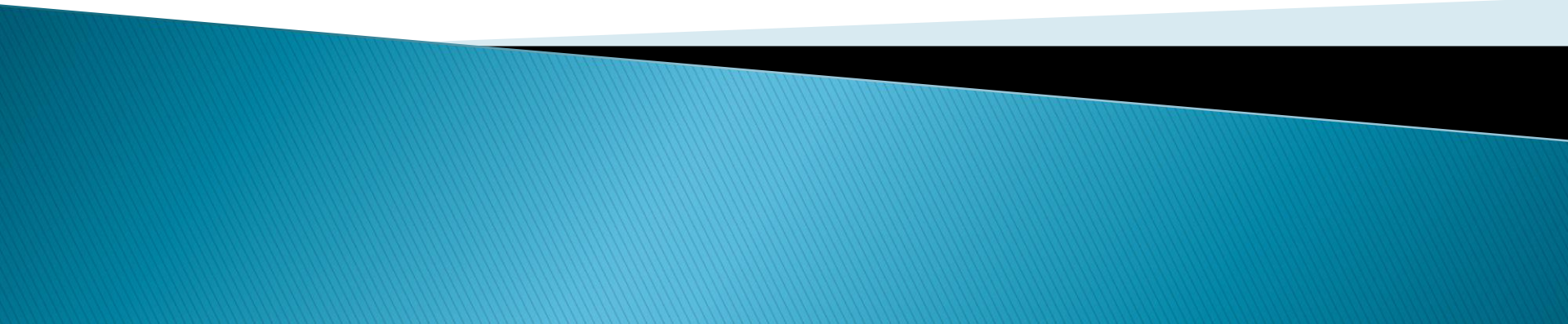
- Due to lack of appropriate awareness about the nature, scope and subject matter of the discipline, different misconceptions are held about anthropology.
- Area of its study
- Only study the rural people and rural areas.
- The study/analysis of fossil evidences of the proto-humans
- Purpose of anthropology is to study in order to keep and preserve communities

The Contributions of anthropology

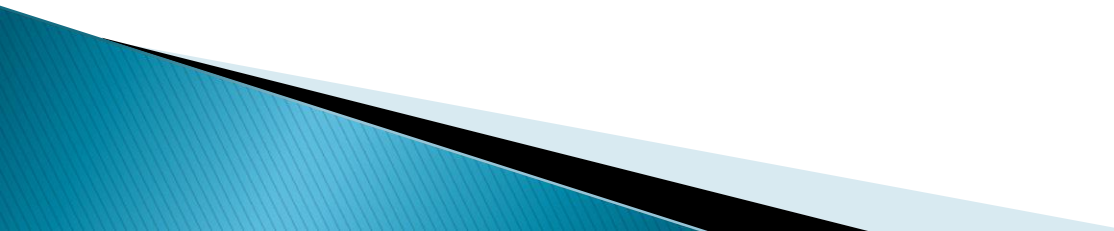
- Lead us to the conclusion that our culture is just one way of life among many found in the world and that it represents one way (among many possible ways) to adapt to a particular set of environmental conditions.
- Helps us better understand ourselves or our own ways of life.
- Helps to understand the logic and justification behind group behavior and cultural practices.
- Used as a tool for development. Paying attention to local conditions, is crucial to solve community problems.

Unit Two

Human Culture and Ties that Connect



Conceptualizing Culture: What Culture is and What Culture isn't

- ▶ “a complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society” (Edward B. Tylor)
 - ▶ B. Malinowski has defined culture “as cumulative creation of man". He regarded culture as the handiwork of man and the medium through which he achieves his ends.
 - ▶ Robert Bierstedt says, “Culture is the complex whole that consists of everything we think and do and have as members of society.”
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Definition of culture...

- ▶ Culture therefore, is moral, intellectual and spiritual discipline for advancement, in accordance with the norms and values based on accumulated heritage. Culture is a system of learned behavior shared by and transmitted among the members of the group.
 - ▶ Culture is a collective heritage learned by individuals and passed from one generation to another. The individual receives culture as part of social heritage and in turn, may reshape the culture and introduce changes which then become part of the heritage of succeeding generations.
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Characteristic Features of Culture

Culture Is Learned

- ▶ Culture is not transmitted genetically rather; it is acquired through the process of learning or interacting with one's environment. More than any other species human relies for their survival on behavior patterns that are learned. Humans have no instinct, which is genetically programmed to direct to behave in a particular way. This process of acquiring culture after we are born is called **enculturation**.
- ▶ **Enculturation** is specifically defined as the process by which an individual learns the rules and values of one's culture.

Culture Is Dynamic:

- ▶ There are no cultures that remain completely static year after year. Culture is changing constantly as new ideas and new techniques are added as time passes modifying or changing the old ways. This is the characteristic of culture that stems from the culture's cumulative quality.

▶ **Culture Is Shared:**

- ▶ For a thing, idea, or behavior pattern to qualify as being “cultural” it must have a shared meaning by at least two people within a society. In order for a society to operate effectively, the guidelines must be shared by its members. Without shared culture members of a society would be unable to communicate and cooperates and confusion and disorder world result.

▶ **Culture Is Symbolic:**

- ▶ Symbolic thought is unique and crucial to humans and to cultural learning. A symbol is something verbal or nonverbal, within a particular language or culture that comes to stand for something else. There need be no obvious, natural, or necessary connection between the symbol and what it symbolizes.

▶ **Culture Is All-Encompassing**

- ▶ Culture encompasses all aspects, which affect people in their everyday lives. Culture comprises countless material and non-material aspects of human lives. Thus, when we talk about a particular people’s culture, we are referring to all of its man- made objects, ideas, activities whether those of traditional, old time things of the past or those created lately. Culture is the sum total of human creation: intellectual, technical, artistic, physical, and moral; it is the complex pattern of living that directs human social life, and which each new generation must learn and to which they eventually add with the dynamics of the social world and the changing environmental conditions.

Culture Is Integrated:

- ▶ Cultures are not haphazard collections of customs and beliefs. Instead, culture should be thought of as integrated wholes, the parts of which, to some degree, are interconnected with one another. When we view cultures as integrated systems, we can begin to see how particular culture traits fit into the whole system and, consequently, how they tend to make sense within that context.
- ▶ A culture is a system, change in one aspect will likely generate changes in other aspects. A good way of describing this integrated nature of culture is by using the analogy between a culture and a living organism. The physical human body comprises a number of systems, all functioning to maintain the overall health of the organisms, including among others, such system as the respiratory system, the digestive system, the skeletal system, excretory system, the reproductive system, and lymphatic system.

Culture Can Be Adaptive and Maladaptive:

- ▶ Humans have both biological and cultural ways of coping with environmental stresses. Besides our biological means of adaptation, we also use "cultural adaptive kits," which contain customary activities and tools that aid us.
- ▶ People adapt themselves to the environment using culture. The ability to adapt themselves to practically any ecological condition, unlike other animals, makes humans unique.

Aspects / Elements of Culture

Material culture

- ▶ Material culture consist of man-made objects such as tools, implements, furniture, automobiles, buildings, dams, roads, bridges, and in fact, the physical substance which has been changed and used by man. It is concerned with the external, mechanical and utilitarian objects. It includes technical and material equipment. It is referred to as civilization.

Non – Material culture

- ▶ The term ‘culture’ when used in the ordinary sense, means ‘non-material culture’. It is something internal and intrinsically valuable, reflects the inward nature of man. Non-material culture consists of the words the people use or the language they speak, the beliefs they hold, values and virtues they cherish, habits they follow, rituals and practices that they do and the ceremonies they observe. It also includes our customs and tastes, attitudes and outlook, in brief, our ways of acting, feeling and thinking. Some of the aspects of non-material culture listed as follows:

Values:

- ▶ Values are the standards by which member of a society define what is good or bad, beautiful or ugly. Every society develops both values and expectations regarding the right way to reflect them.
- ▶ Values are a central aspect of the nonmaterial culture of a society and are important because they influence the behavior of the members of a society.

Beliefs

- ▶ Beliefs are cultural conventions that concern true or false assumptions, specific descriptions of the nature of the universe and humanity's place in it. Values are generalized notions of what is good and bad; beliefs are more specific and, in form at least, have more content. "Education is good" is a fundamental value in American society, whereas "Grading is the best way to evaluate students" is a belief that reflects assumptions about the most appropriate way to determine educational achievement.

Norms

- ▶ Norms are another aspect of nonmaterial culture. Norms are shared rules or guidelines that define how people "ought" to behave under certain circumstances. Norms are generally connected to the values, beliefs, and ideologies of a society.

Norms vary in terms of their importance to a culture, these are:

- a) **Folkway**: Norms guiding ordinary usages and conventions of everyday life are known as folkways. Folkways are norms that are not strictly enforced, such as not leaving your seat for an elderly people inside a bus/taxi. They may result in a person getting a bad look.
- b) **Mores**: Mores are much stronger norms than are folkways. Mores are norms that are believed to be essential to core values and we insist on conformity. A person who steals, rapes, and kills has violated some of society's most important mores.

People who violate mores are usually severely punished, although punishment for the violation of mores varies from society to society. It may take the form of ostracism, vicious gossip, public ridicule, exile, loss of one's job, physical beating, imprisonment, commitment to a mental asylum, or even execution

Evaluating Cultural Differences

Ethnocentrism: refers to the tendency to see the behaviors, beliefs, values, and norms of one's own group as the only right way of living and to judge others by those standards.

Cultural relativism: states that cultures differ, so that a cultural trait, act, or idea has no meaning but its meaning only within its cultural setting. Cultural relativism suspends judgment and views about the behavior of people from the perspective of their own culture.

Cultural relativism describes a situation where there is an attitude of respect for cultural differences rather than condemning other people's culture as uncivilized or backward.

Respect for cultural differences involves:

- ❖ Appreciating cultural diversity;
 - ❖ Accepting and respecting other cultures;
 - ❖ Trying to understand every culture and its elements in terms of its own context and logic;
 - ❖ Accepting that each body of custom has inherent dignity and meaning as the way of life of one group which has worked out to its environment, to the biological needs of its members, and to the group relationships;
 - ❖ Knowing that a person's own culture is only one among many; and
 - ❖ Recognizing that what is immoral, ethical, acceptable, etc, in one culture may not be so in another culture.
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Human rights

- ▶ Human rights: rights based on justice and morality beyond and superior to particular countries, cultures, and religions. The idea of human rights challenges cultural relativism by invoking a realm of justice and morality beyond and superior to the laws and customs of particular countries, cultures, and religions.
- ▶ Human rights include the right to ***speak freely***, to ***hold religious*** beliefs without persecution, and to not be murdered, injured, or enslaved or imprisoned without charge. Such rights are seen as inalienable (nations cannot abridge or terminate them) and international (larger than and superior to individual nations and cultures). A doctrine of universal human rights, which emphasizes the rights of the individual over those of the community, would condemn such killings.
- ▶ Anthropologists respect human diversity. Most ethnographers try to be objective, accurate, and sensitive in their accounts of other cultures. However, their objectivity, sensitivity and a cross-cultural perspective got nothing to do with ignoring international standards of justice and morality.

Culture Change

- ▶ Culture change can occur as a result of the following Mechanisms:

Diffusion: The source of new cultural elements in a society may also be another society. The process by which cultural elements are borrowed from another society and incorporated into the culture of the recipient group is called diffusion.

Diffusion is **direct** when two cultures trade with, intermarry among, or wage war on one another.

Diffusion is **forced** when one culture subjugates another and imposes its customs on the dominated group.

Diffusion is **indirect** when items or traits move from group A to group C via group B without any firsthand contact between A and C. In this case, group B might consist of traders or merchants who take products from a variety of places to new markets. Or group B might be geographically situated between A and C, so that what it gets from A eventually winds up in C, and vice versa. In today's world, much international diffusion is indirect-culture spread by the mass media and advanced information technology.

Acculturation: Is the exchange of cultural features that results when groups have continuous firsthand contact.

The cultures of either or both groups may be changed by this contact. This usually happens in situations of trade or colonialism. In situations of continuous contact, cultures have also exchanged and blended foods, recipes, music, dances, clothing, tools, and technologies.

Invention is the process by which humans innovate, creatively finding solutions to problems is a third mechanism of cultural change. Faced with comparable problems and challenges, people in different societies have innovated and changed in similar ways, which is one reason cultural generalities exist.



► Globalization

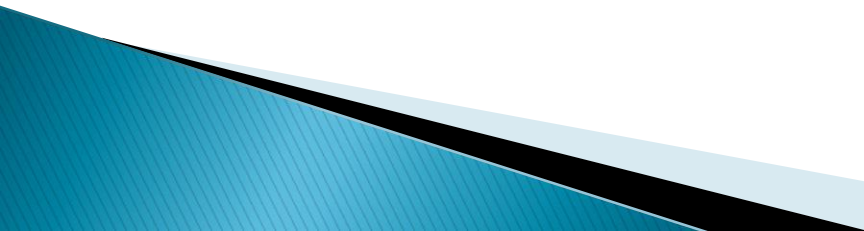
- The term globalization encompasses a series of processes, including diffusion and acculturation, working to promote change in a world in which nations and people are increasingly interlinked and mutually dependent. Promoting such linkages are economic and political forces, as well as modern systems of transportation and communication. Due to globalization, long-distance communication is easier, faster, and cheaper than ever, and extends to remote areas. The mass media help propel a globally spreading culture of consumption. Within nations and across their borders, the media spread information about products, services, rights, institutions, lifestyles, and the perceived costs and benefits of globalization. Emigrants transmit information and resources transnational, as they maintain their ties with home (phoning, faxing, e-mailing, making visits, and sending money). In a sense such people live multilocally-in different places and cultures at once. They learn to play various social roles and to change behavior and identity depending on the situation.

Ties That Connect: Marriage, Family and Kinship

▶ **MARRIAGE**

- ▶ Marriage is a ***social process*** that creates new relationships by transforming the status of the participants, stipulates the degree of sexual access the married partners may have to each other, positions children, and creates relationships between the kin of the partners.
- ▶ Sociologists define marriage as a ***socially support*** union involving two or more individuals in what is regarded as a stable, enduring arrangement typically based at least in part on a sexual bond of some kind.
- ▶ Marriage is a ***permanent legal union*** between a man and a woman. It is an important institution without which the society could never be sustained.
- ▶ Marriage may be defined as a ***socially acknowledged and approved sexual union*** between two adult individuals. When two people marry, they become kin one another; the marriage bond also, however, connects together a wider range of kin people. Parents, sisters, brothers and other blood relatives become relatives of the partner through marriage.

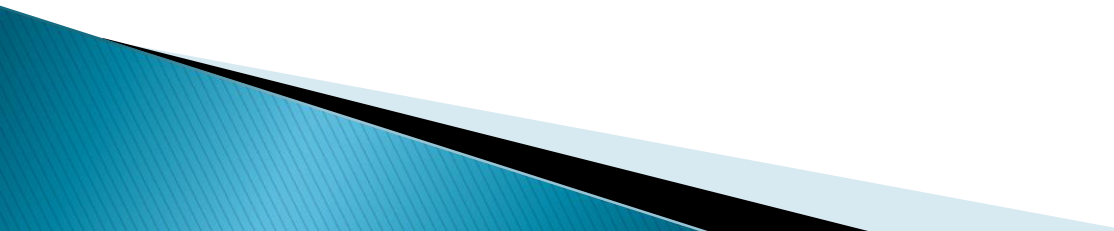
Whom Should You Marry?

- ▶ Cultural expectations define appropriate potential marriage partners.
 - ▶ People are sometimes expected to marry within religious communities, to marry someone who is ethnically or racially similar or who comes from a similar economic or educational background.
 - ▶ Cultural norms, and often laws, identify people as suitable or unsuitable marriage partners.
 - ▶ Some of these forms of mate selection include:
 - ▶ **Endogamy:** This is a marriage practice of selecting mates only from within one's own social group, especially from one's own ethnic group.
 - ▶ **Exogamy:** This is mate selection outside one's social group or ethnic group.
 - ▶ **Hypergamy:** A marriage between a high class man and a low class woman in society.
 - ▶ **Hypogamy:** Marriage between a high class woman and a low class man.
 - ▶ **Homogamy:** Mate selection based on similar characteristics between couple such as; educational, religious and race affiliation.
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Types of marriage

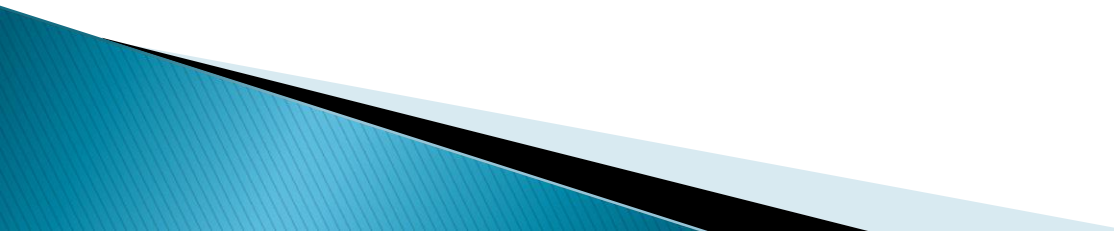
- ▶ **A) Exogamy:** This is the rule by which a man is not allowed to marry someone from his own social group.
- ▶ Such prohibited union is designated as **incest**. Incest is often considered as sin.
- ▶ In rural areas of India, for example, people are expected to marry someone of the same caste (endogamy) but from a different village (exogamy). On the one hand, the logic of endogamy is that people of similar position pass along their standing to their offspring, thereby maintaining the traditional social hierarchy. Exogamy, on the other, builds alliances and encourages cultural diffusion.

There are some definite reasons for which practice of exogamy got approval. They are:

- ▶ A ***conception of blood*** relation prevails among the members of a group. Therefore, marriage within the group-members is considered a marriage between a brother and sister
 - ▶ Attraction between a male and female gets *lost due* to close relationship in a small group.
 - ▶ There is a popular idea that a great increase of energy and vigor is possible in the progeny if marriage binds two extremely distant persons who possess no kin relation among them.
 - ▶ Kottak claimed also that exogamy has adaptive value, because it links people into a wider social network that nurtures, helps, and protects them in times of need pushing social organization outward, establishing and preserving alliances among groups.
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B) Endogamy: A rule of endogamy requires individuals to *marry within their own group and forbids them to marry outside it.*

Endogamy limits marriage prospects to others of the same age, race, religion, or social class. Religious groups such as the Amish, Mormons, Catholics, and Jews have rules of endogamy, though these are often violated when marriage take place outside the group. Castes in India and Nepal are also endogamous. “Indeed, most cultures are endogamous units, although they usually do not need a formal rule requiring people to marry someone from their own society”.

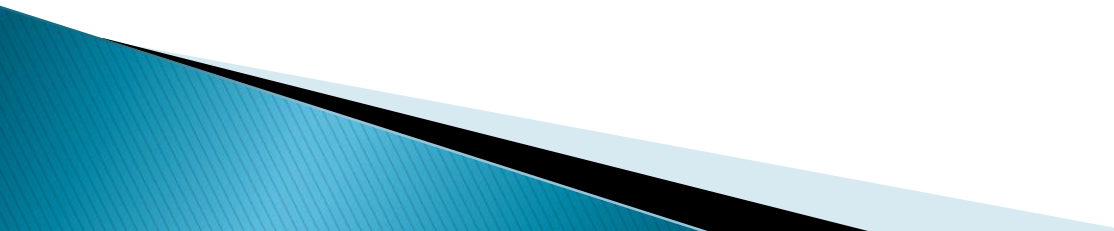


C) Preferential Cousin Marriage:

A common form of preferred marriage is called preferential cousin marriage and is practiced in one form or another in most of the major regions of the world. Kinship systems based on lineages distinguish between two different types of first cousins, these are:

Cross Cousins: are children of siblings of the opposite sex- that is one's mother's brothers' children and one's father's sisters' children.

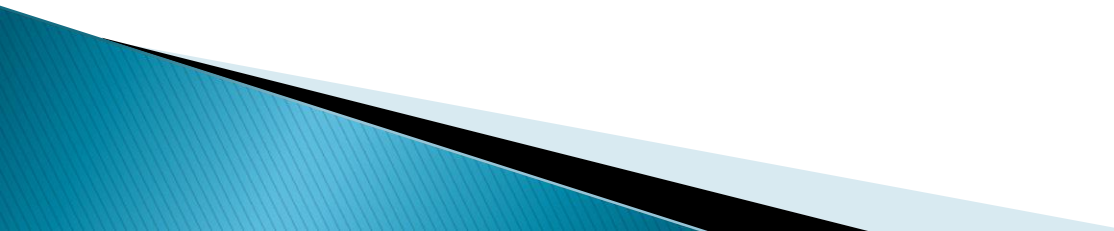
Parallel Cousins: When marriage takes place between the children of the siblings of the same sex, it is called parallel cousin marriage. are children of siblings of the same sex, namely the children of one's mother's sister and one's father brother. The mate may come either from one's father's brother's children or mother's sister's children.



D) Levirate and Sororate

- ▶ **The levirate-** is the custom whereby a widow is expected to marry the brother (or some close male relative) of her dead husband. Usually any children fathered by the woman's new husband are considered to belong legally to the dead brother rather than to the actual genitor. Such a custom both serves as a form of social security for the widow and her children and preserved the rights of her husband's family to her sexuality and future children.
- ▶ **The sororate**, which comes into play when a wife dies, is the practice of a widower's marrying the sister (or some close female relative) of his deceased wife. In the event that the deceased spouse has no sibling, the family of the deceased is under a general obligation to supply some equivalent relative as a substitute. For example, in a society that practice sororate, a widower may be given as a substitute wife the daughter of his deceased wife's brother

E) Gift or Charity Marriage

- ▶ In this kind of marriage, parents give out one of their young daughters as a gift to their friends or patrons without any consideration as a demonstration of friendship, honor and total loyalty. In some African societies, the chiefs or kings enjoyed this honor and prerogative among subjects.
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NUMBER OF SPOUSES

- ▶ Societies have rules regulating whom one may/may not marry; they have rules specifying how many mates a person may/should have.
 - ▶ **Monogamy**: the marriage of one man to one woman at a time.
 - ▶ **Polygamy** i.e. marriage of a man or woman with two or more mates. Polygamy can be of two types:
 - ▶ **Polygyny**: the marriage of a man to two or more women at a time.
 - ▶ **Polyandy**: the marriage of a woman to two or more men at a time
 - ▶ **Sororal polygyny**: Marriage of a man with two or more sisters at a time. When the co-wives are not sisters, the marriage is termed as non-sororal polygyny.
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Advantages & Disadvantages of Polygamy marriage

- ▶ Having two/more wives is often seen as a sign of prestige.
 - ▶ Having multiple wives means wealth, power, & status both for the polygynous husband, wives and children.
 - ▶ It produces more children, who are considered valuable for future economic and political assets.
 - ▶ Economic advantage: It encourages to work hard (more cows, goats..) for more wives
 - ▶ The Drawbacks of Polygyny: Jealousy among the co-wives who frequently compete for the husband's attention.
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Economic Consideration of Marriage

Most societies view as a binding contract between at least the husband and wife and, in many cases, between their respective families as well. Such a contract includes the transfer of certain rights between the parties involved: rights of sexual access, legal rights to children, and rights of the spouses to each other's economic goods and services. Often the transfer of rights is accompanied by the transfer of some type of economic consideration. These transactions, which may take place either before or after the marriage can be divided into three categories:

BRIDE PRICE It is also known as bride wealth, is the compensation given upon marriage by the family of the groom to the family of the bride.

BRIDE SERVICE When the groom works for his wife's family, this is known as bride service.

DOWRY A dowry involves a transfer of goods or money in the opposite direction, from the bride's family to the groom's family.

Post–Marital Residence

- ▶ Where the newly married couple lives after the marriage ritual is governed by cultural rules, which are referred to as post-marital residence rule.
- ▶ Patrilocal Residence: the married couple lives with or near the relatives of the *husband's father*.
- ▶ Matrilocal Residence: the married couple lives with or near the relatives of the *wife*.
- ▶ Avunculocal Residence: The married couple lives with or near the *husband's mother's brother*.
- ▶ Ambilocal/Bilocal Residence: The married couple has a choice of living with relatives of the **wife** or relatives of the **husband**
- ▶ Neolocal Residence: The Married couple forms an **independent** place of residence away from the relatives of either spouse.
- ▶ Duolocal or Natolocal: In this marital residence pattern, couples are required to **reside separately**. This means that both husband and wife stay in their families of orientation or in their different apartments and only visit each other.

FAMILY

Family can be defined as the smallest group of individuals who see themselves as connected to one another.

Family is a group of people related by ancestry, marriage or other committed sexual relationship, or adopted and live together, form an economic unit, and rear their children.

Family is a social group whose members are related either through common ancestry or marriage and are bound by moral and economic rights and duties.

Family is the basis of human society. It is the most important primary group in society. The family, as an institution, is universal. It is the most permanent and most pervasive of all social institutions.

- *The family is a group of people related or connected by bloodline, marriage rite or adoption*
- *They share common residency. They live together.*
- *They share sentiments of oneness. They view themselves as a unit.*
- *They share values and responsibilities. Perform caretaking services for others especially the very young.*

Types of family

Cultural anthropologists have identified two fundamentally different types of family structure-the nuclear family and the extended family.

The Nuclear Family:

Consisting of husband and wife and their children, the nuclear family is a two-generation family formed around the conjugal or marital union. Even though the nuclear family to some degree is part of a larger family structure, it remains relatively autonomous and independent unity.

The Extended Family

In societies based on extended families, blood ties are more important than ties of marriage. Extended families consist of two or more families that are linked by blood ties. Most commonly, this takes the form of a married couple living with one or more of their married children in a single household or homestead and under the authority of a family head.

Types of Family According to Authority and Power Structure

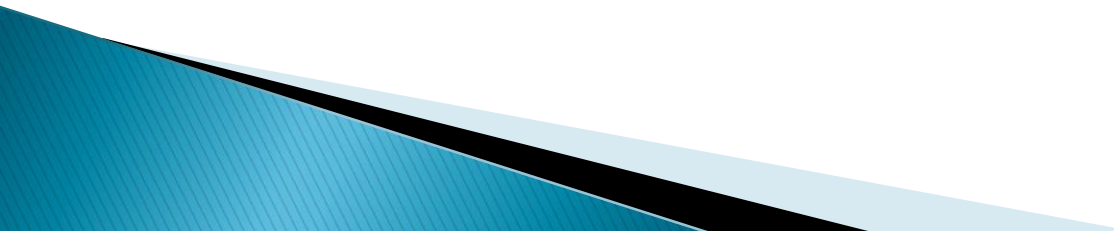
- ▶ **Patriarchal Family:** In this kind of family structure, decision making authority and power lies in the hands of the man whether be it a nuclear family, single family or an extended family. Male headed households are obtainable in most societies; and in absence of the man, the eldest son becomes the leader of the household.
- ▶ **Matriarchal Family:** This is a female headed family. *Here authority is vested on the woman, resulting especially where the man or husband of a woman has died, or when the men desert their wives.*
- ▶ **Egalitarian Family:** This describes an arrangement in the family where power and decision-making authority are equally distributed between the husband and wife. Due to education, skills, paid employment for women, women emancipation programmes in recent times, women now share equal authorities with men in the family as they jointly contribute to the family welfare etc.

Functions Marriage and Family

- ▶ Family performs certain specific functions which can be mentioned as follows:
- ▶ **Biological Function:** The institution of marriage and family serves biological (sexual and reproductive) function.
- ▶ **Economic Function:** Marriage brings economic co-operation between men and women and ensure survival of individuals in a society.
- ▶ **Social Function** the institution of marriage brings with it the creation and perpetuation of the family, the form of person to person relations and linking once kin group to another kin group.
- ▶ **Educational and Socialization Function:** The burden of socialization (via processes of enculturation and education) of new born infants fall primarily upon the family. In addition, children learn an immense amount of knowledge, culture, values prescribed by society, before they assume their place as adult members of a society.

KINSHIP

- ▶ kinship is a network of relations expressed in ties of obligations, claims to resources, statutes, property rights, duties, power, privileges, authority and obedience, social security, mutual assistance and sexual behavior
- ▶ Kinship ties are connections between individuals, established either through marriage or through the lines of descent that connect blood relatives (mothers, fathers, siblings, offspring, etc.).
- ▶ Kinship includes the terms, or social statuses, used to define family members and the roles or expected behaviors family associated with these statuses. Kinship encompasses relationships formed **through blood** connections (consanguineal), such as those created between parents and children, as well as relationships created **through marriage** ties (affinal), such as in-laws. Kinship can also include “chosen kin,” who have no formal blood or marriage ties, but consider themselves to be family. Adoptive parents, for instance, are culturally recognized as parents to the children they raise even though they are not related by blood.

- ▶ Kinship is the method of reckoning relationship. In any society every adult individual belongs to two different nuclear families. The family in which he was born and reared is called '**family of orientation**'. The other family to which he establishes relation through marriage is called '**family of procreation**'. A kinship system is neither a social group nor does it correspond to organized aggregation of individuals. It is a structured system of relationships where individuals are bound together by complex interlocking and ramifying ties.
 - ▶ kinship could be derived from four principles;
 - ▶ *Blood or consanguinity*
 - ▶ *Marriage or affinity*
 - ▶ *Adoption and*
 - ▶ *Ritual or fiction*
- 

DESCENT

► Descent refers to the social recognition of the biological relationship that exists between the individuals. The rule of descent refers to a set of principles by which an individual traces his descent. In almost all societies kinship connections are very significant. An individual always possesses certain obligations towards his kinsmen and he also expects the same from his kinsmen. Succession and inheritance is related to this rule of descent. There are three important rules of descent as follows;

Patrilineal descent When descent is traced solely through the male line, it is called patrilineal descent. A man's sons and daughters all belong to the same descent group by birth, but it only the sons who continue the affiliation. Succession and inheritance pass through the male line.

Matrilineal descent When the descent is traced solely through the female line. It is called matrilineal descent. At birth, children of both sexes belong to mother's descent group, but later only females acquire the succession and inheritance. Therefore, daughters carry the tradition, generation after generation.

Cognatic Descent In some society's individuals are free to show their genealogical links either through men or women. Some people of such society are therefore connected with the kin-group of father and others with the kin group of mothers. There is no fixed rule to trace the succession and inheritance; any combination of lineal link is possible in such societies.

UNIT FOUR
MARGINALIZED, MINORITIES, AND
VULNERABLE GROUPS

Definition of concepts

- ***What is marginalization?*** Marginalization is defined as a treatment of a person or social group as minor, insignificant or peripheral. Marginalization involves **exclusion** of certain groups from ***social interactions, marriage relations, sharing food and drinks, and working and living together.***
- ***Who are mostly marginalized?*** There are marginalized social groups in every society and culture. *Women, children, older people, and people with disabilities* are among marginalized groups across the world. The nature and level of marginalization varies from society to society as a result of cultural diversity. **Religious, ethnic, and racial minorities** are also among social groups marginalized in different societies and cultures. Crafts workers such as tanners, potters, and ironsmiths are marginalized in many parts of Ethiopia.

- **What is vulnerability?** Vulnerability refers to the state of **being exposed to physical or emotional injuries**. Vulnerable groups are people exposed to possibilities of attack, harms or mistreatment. As a result, vulnerable persons/groups need special attention, protection and support. For example, children and people with disabilities need special support and protection as they are exposed to risks and neglect because of their age and disabilities. Universities have introduced special needs education for students with disabilities to give them special support.
- **Minority groups:** The phrase ‘minority group’ refers to a **small group of people** within a community, region, or country. In most cases, minority groups are different from the majority population in terms of race, religion, ethnicity, and language. For example, black Americans are minorities in the United States of America. Christians could be minorities in a Muslim majority country. Muslims can be minorities in a predominantly Hindu society. Hence, minority groups can be **ethnic minorities, religious minorities, or racial minorities** in a given community, region of country.

Gender-based marginalization

- Gender inequality involves discrimination on a group of people based on their **gender**. Gender inequality mainly arises from socio-cultural norms. The manifestations of gender inequality varies from culture to culture. Girls and women face negative discrimination in societies across the world. Women are exposed to social and economic inequalities involving unfair distribution of wealth, income and job opportunities.
- Gender-based marginalization is a global problem. It involves exclusion of girls and women from a *wide range of opportunities and social services*. Gender disparities in education is a good example. Girls in developing countries, especially those who live in remote and rural areas, are excluded from formal education. The enrollment of girls in higher education is much lower than that of boys. Women do not enjoy equal employment opportunities. They do not have equal rights in terms of property ownership and inheritance. Women and girls are also vulnerable to gender-based violence such as **rape, early/child marriage, abduction/forced marriage, domestic violence and female genital cutting/mutilation**.
- There are some customary practices that affect the health and wellbeing of girls and women. These practices collectively are **called harmful traditional practices (HTPs)**.

Female Genital Mutilation/cutting

- Female genital mutilation (FGM) includes all procedures that involve the *partial or total removal of external genitalia or other injury* to the female genital organs (such as stitching of the labia majora or pricking of the clitoris) for non-medical reasons . *In addition* to having no health benefits, FGM interferes with normal body functions and can have a negative effect on several aspects of a girl's or woman's life, including her **physical, mental and sexual** health and her relationship with her husband or partner and other close family members.

WHERE AND AT WHAT AGE IS FGM PERFORMED?

- FGM is a **global concern**. To date, the practice is reported in 30 countries in Africa and in a few countries in Asia and the Middle East. Some forms of FGM are also reported to occur among certain ethnic groups in Central and South America, and Eastern Europe. The rise in international migration has also increased the number of girls and women living in the various diasporas populations, including in Australia, Europe, New Zealand and North America, and who have undergone or may undergo the practice.
- The age at which girls experience FGM varies across countries and cultural groups. In some communities, FGM is performed before girls turn five years old, but in others, girls are cut when they are between the ages of five and 14 years, or prior to marriage.

WHY DO COMMUNITIES PRACTISE FGM?

- **RESPECT FOR TRADITION**

- FGM is often seen as part of the history and cultural tradition of the community. Community members, including the women, often support and continue the practice because they see it as a sign of respect towards the elder members of the community.

- **RITE OF PASSAGE**

- In many cultures, FGM constitutes an important rite of passage into adulthood for girls. Often the event is marked with a ceremony and/or celebration. It may be considered a necessary step towards being viewed as a respectable adult woman.

- **SOCIAL CONVENTION**

- Where FGM is widely practiced, it is considered a social convention. Those who adhere to the practice may be better accepted in their communities, while those who do not may face condemnation, harassment and exclusion.

- **ENHANCE FERTILITY**

- In some practicing communities, women and men believe that if a woman is not cut she will not be able to become pregnant or she may face difficulties during labor.

WHY...

- **MARRIAGEABILITY**

- There is often an expectation that men will marry only women who have undergone FGM. The desire and pressure to be married, and the economic and social security that may come with marriage, can perpetuate the practice in some settings.

- **ENSURE VIRGINITY, CHASTITY AND FAITHFULNESS**

- FGM is believed to safeguard a girl's or woman's virginity prior to marriage and ensure fidelity after marriage. Therefore, families may believe that FGM protects a girl's and her family's honor.

- **CLEANLINESS AND BEAUTY**

- In some communities, FGM is performed in order to make girls "clean" and beautiful. Cleanliness may refer to the body; female genitals that are cut or closed are sometimes seen as more hygienic and beautiful, but it may also refer to spiritual purity.

- **FEMININITY**

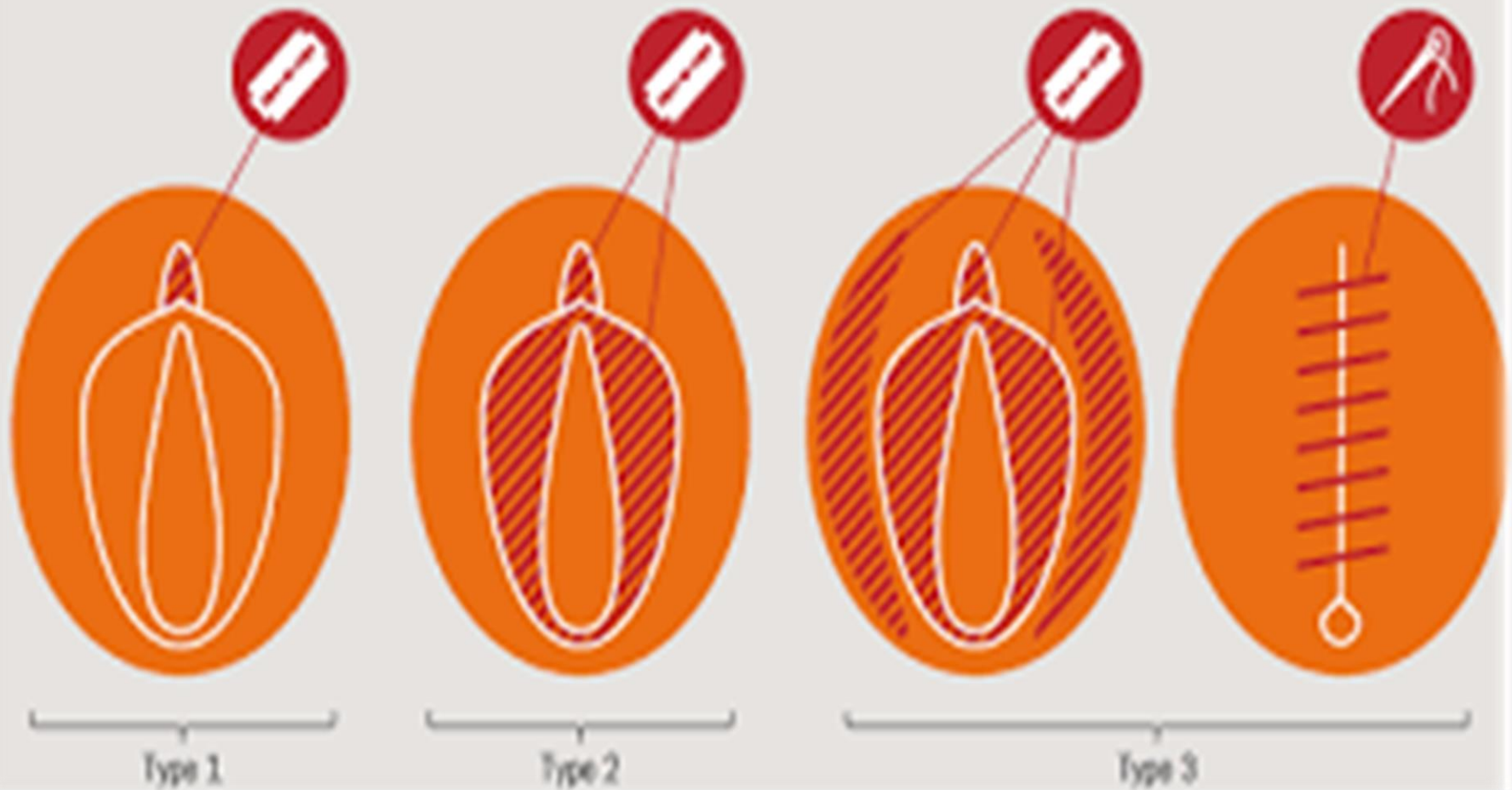
- The removal of genital parts that are considered masculine (i.e. the clitoris) is considered to make girls more feminine, respectable and beautiful.

- **RELIGION**

- Some communities believe that FGM is a religious requirement, and some religious leaders may promote the practice, even though it is not mentioned in any major religious texts.

CLASSIFICATION OF FGM

Different types of female genital mutilation



- **TYPE I**

- Partial or total removal of the clitoral glans (the external and visible part of the clitoris, which is a sensitive part of the female genitals, which is a sensitive part of the female genitals, with the function of providing sexual pleasure to the woman), and/or the prepuce/clitoral hood (the fold of skin surrounding the clitoral glans).
- Type IA: removal of the prepuce/clitoral hood only.
- Type IB . Removal of the clitoral glans with the prepuce/clitoral hood.

- **TYPE II**

- Partial or total removal of the clitoral glans and the labia minora (the inner folds of the vulva), with or without removal of the labia majora (the outer folds of skin of the vulva).
- Type IIA. Removal of the labia minora only.
- Type IIB. Partial or total removal of the clitoral glans and the labia minora (prepuce/clitoral hood may be affected).
- Type IIC. Partial or total removal of the clitoral glans, the labia minora and the labia majora (prepuce/clitoral hood may be affected).

- **Type III.** (Often referred to as infibulations).
- Narrowing of the vaginal opening with the creation of a covering seal. The seal is formed by cutting and repositioning the labia minora, or labia majora. The covering of the vaginal opening is done with or without removal of the clitoral prepuce/clitoral hood and glans (Type I FGM).
- **Type IIIA.** Removal and repositioning of the labia minora.
- **Type IIIB.** Removal and repositioning of the labia majora.
- **Type IV.** All other harmful procedures to the female genitalia for non-medical purposes, for example pricking, piercing, incising, scraping and cauterization.

Marginalized occupational groups

According to anthropological findings, there are occupational marginalized groups in many parts of Ethiopia. The following are marginalized occupational groups in our country: *tanners, potters, weavers and ironsmiths*. These craft-workers have different names in different parts of the country. Craft-workers such as potters and tanners are considered as impure and excluded from social interactions, ownership of economic resources (e.g., land), and participation in associations and celebrations.

Marginalized occupation groups are people engaged in craftworks such as pottery, tannery, and iron works. Craft-workers in Ethiopia produce several articles such as traditional hand-woven clothes, household utensils, and farm tools. Crafts workers lead a life of paradoxes. They have important contributions to their communities; however, they are marginalized by the dominant and majority groups. For examples, weavers produce cultural clothes highly demanded by thousands and millions of people. Many people use cultural clothes during annual celebrations, religious holidays, weddings, culture days, and mourning. The demand of cultural dresses has been increasing in the last three decades. People dress cultural clothes in different occasions such as cultural festivals, days of nations and nationalities, and religious celebrations. Despite their contributions, weavers are marginalized from the wider society.

Major types of marginalization in Ethiopia

Spatial marginalization

Craft-workers settle/live on the outskirts of villages, near to forests, on poor land, around steep slopes.

They are segregated at market places (they sell their goods at the outskirts of markets).

When they walk along the road, they are expected to give way for others and walk on the lower side of the road.

Economic marginalization

Craft-workers are excluded from certain economic activities including production and exchanges. In some cultures they are not allowed to cultivate crops.

They have a limited access to land and land ownership.

Social marginalization

Craft-workers are excluded from intermarriage, they do not share burial places with others; they are excluded from membership of associations such as iddirs.

When marginalized groups are allowed to participate in social events, they must sit on the floor separately-sometimes outside the house or near the door.

Cultural marginalization

Occupational minorities are labeled as impure and polluting; they are accused of eating animals that have died without being slaughtered;

Occupational minorities are also considered unreliable, lacking morality, respect and shame.

Age-based vulnerability

- What is age-based vulnerability? Age-based vulnerability is susceptibility of people, especially children and older people, to different forms of attack, physical injuries and emotional harms. For example, children and older people (people aged 60 and above) are exposed to possibilities of attack, harm and mistreatment because of their age. As a result, vulnerable persons/groups need special attention, protection and support.

Children: Discrimination/vulnerability

- Children are among vulnerable groups exposed to harm because of their age. Both boys and girls are exposed to some harm and abuse in the hands of older people. However, girls are exposed to double marginalization and discrimination because of the gender. Child girls are exposed to various kinds of harm before they reach at the age of maturity.

Early/child marriage: Early marriage refers to marriage which involves girls below the age of 18. The prevalence of early marriage is declining in Ethiopia and other African countries. However, it is still widely practiced in different regions of Ethiopia. According to international human rights conventions, early marriage is regarded as violation of the rights of the child. Early marriage has the following major harmful consequences:

- Young girls enter into marital relation when they are too young to give their **consent to get married**.
- inhibits girls' **personal development**; it hinders girls' chance to education and future professional development.
- exposes young girls to **sexual abuse** by their older husbands.
- leads to **early pregnancies**, which increases risks of diseases and complications during delivery, fistula, and death of the mother or child.

Factors encouraging early marriage

- **Social norms:** Social norms contribute a lot for the continuation of early marriage in many parts of the world. Chastity of girls is one of the social norms that influence parents and relatives to protecting girls from pre-marital sex. The value attached to virginity is another driver of early marriage. Girl's reputation and family social status are associated with sexual purity of girls. Parents incline to marry off their daughter before the girl reach at the stage of poverty to avoid the possibility of pre-marital sex and love affair.
- **Economic factors** are among the major factors that drive child marriage. In many areas of Ethiopia marriage provides economic security for young girls. Hence, parents, in some cases girls, support early marriage for economic benefits such as access to land and other resources. Parents' desire to get a good husband for their daughter is also another reason.

Marginalization of older persons

- The phrase 'older people' refers to adults with the **age of 60 and above**. The number of older people is increasing globally. According to the estimation of the United Nations (2009), the number of older people will increase to 2 billion by 2050. Eighty percent of the 2 billion older persons would live in low and middle-income countries. This means Africa would have a large number of older adults after 30 years. Ethiopia, the second populous country in Africa, would also have millions of older persons after three decades.
- Ageism is a widely observed social problem in the world. Ageism refer to ***stereotyping, prejudice, and discrimination against people based on their age***. Older women and men enjoyed a certain level of support and respected in the past. This was true in many cultures of Ethiopia in the past. Things have been changing in recent times. Older people are facing various problems as a result of modernization, globalization, and urbanization. Older people are exposed to social exclusion because of their lower social and economic status. In most cases, older people are excluded from social, cultural, political and economic interactions in their communities. Older persons are marginalized because they are considered as social burden rather than social assets. Communities do not provide older persons with opportunities to contribute to their communities.

Religious and ethnic minorities

- Religious and ethnic minorities groups also face different forms of marginalization. There are several examples of marginalization and discrimination targeting religious and ethnic minorities in the world. Let us mention two examples.
- The Jewish people suffered from discrimination and persecution in different parts of the world. They were targets of extermination in Germany and other Western European countries because of their identity.
- Muslim Rohingyas are among the most marginalized and persecuted people in the world. According to Abdu Hasnat Milton et al (2017), the Rohingyas are 'one of the most ill-treated and persecuted refugee groups in the world'. In recent years, more than half-a-million Rohingyas fled from their homes in Myanmar to neighboring countries such as Bangladesh. As people living in refugee camps, the Rohingyas are vulnerable to problems such as malnutrition and physical and sexual abuse.
- These are among the widely known examples of discrimination against religious and ethnic minorities. The problem is not limited to specific areas, regions or countries. Although the level of the problem varies in different contexts, religious and ethnic minorities face different forms of discrimination in many parts of the world.

Human right approaches and inclusiveness: Anthropological perspectives

- All forms of marginalization and discrimination against vulnerable and minority groups contradict the principles of human rights. The major human rights conventions *denounce discrimination against women, children, people with disability, older people and other minority and vulnerable groups*. People with disabilities have the right to inclusive services and equal opportunities. The human rights of women and girls include right to be free from harmful traditional practices such as forced marriage, early marriage, and female genital cutting. Any form of discrimination, exclusion, and gender-based violence also violate the human rights girls and women.

Unit Five
Identity, Inter-Ethnic
Relations and
Multiculturalism in
Ethiopia

IDENTITY, ETHNICITY AND RACE:
*IDENTIFICATION AND SOCIAL
CATEGORIZATION*

What is Ethnicity?

**Boundary/Ascription
as a Defining Feature
of Ethnicity**

**Culture as a Basic Defining
Feature of Ethnicity**



CULTURE AS A BASIC DEFINING FEATURE OF ETHNICITY

The criteria which constitute ethnicity vary. For a long time it was common to equate ethnic groups with cultural groups; any category of people who had a shared culture was considered as an ethnic group. However, this position has become difficult to justify. This is because; **the sharing of cultural traits frequently crosses group boundaries and**, moreover, people do not always share all their 'cultural traits' with the same people. One may have the same language as some people, the same religion as some of those as well as of some others, and the same economic strategy as an altogether different category of people. In other words, cultural boundaries are not clear-cut, nor do they necessarily correspond with ethnic boundaries. ***Ethnicity is an aspect of relationship, not a cultural property of a group***. If a setting is wholly mono-ethnic, there is effectively no ethnicity, since there is nobody there to communicate cultural difference to.

- The Ethiopian constitutional triplet of "Nations, Nationalities, and Peoples" (the Amharic *behieroch*, *behiereseboch*, *ena hezboch*) are defined in Article 39 of the Federal Constitution defines as: "*a group of people who have or share a large measure of a common culture, or similar customs, mutual intelligibility of language, belief in a common or related identity, and who predominantly inhabit an identifiable, contiguous territory.*"
- There are three main kinds of ethnic community in the historical record. These are: ***ethno linguistic communities***, in which language is the most salient and vital element in the definition of ethnicity and the mobilization of ethnic sentiments; ***ethno-religious communities***, which have been defined and have defined themselves, primarily in terms of religious beliefs, practices, and symbols; and ***ethno-political communities***, that have defined themselves, and been defined, by historical memories and political traditions

BOUNDARY/AScription AS A DEFINING FEATURE OF ETHNICITY

Ethnic group is a group of people who identify with one another, or are so identified by others, on the ***basis of a boundary that distinguishes them from other groups***. Fredrik Barth (1969a) argues that: the focus ought to be the *boundaries* which delimit the group and not the 'cultural stuffs' it encloses. Cultural variation may be an effect and not a cause of boundaries. If the mutual dichotomization between two groups (that were formerly same group) continues and the national borders between their states become permanent, it is likely that languages as well as other aspects of culture of the two will gradually become more distinctive.

In other words, an ethnic group is defined through **its relationships to others, highlighted through the boundary**. Ethnicity refers to aspects of relationships between groups whose members consider themselves, and are regarded by others, as being culturally distinctive. When cultural differences regularly make a difference in interaction between members of groups, the social relationship has an ethnic element. There is no ethnicity unless groups have a minimum of contact with each other and entertain ideas of each other as being culturally different from themselves. Ethnicity is categorical as ascriptions between 'Us' and 'Them'.

CONT...

- All approaches agree that ethnicity has something to do with the classification of people and group relationships. Ethnicity is the application of **systematic distinctions between insiders and outsiders**; between **Us** and **Them**. Dichotomization between insiders and outsiders; the process of self-ascription/attribution and ascription by others shapes the process of interaction among groups. If no such principle (social contact) exists there can be no ethnicity. However, ethnic boundary may change through time; it may shrink or expand, blurred or glared depending on situations and contexts. The compass of the 'We' category may expand and contract according to the situation. Depending on situations, different levels of group membership could be activated. There are different Us and Them groups. In some cases, ethnic identities are imposed from outside, by dominant groups, on those who do not themselves want membership in the group to which they are assigned.

- In spite of the difference in scholarly views of ethnicity among anthropologists, the 'basic social anthropological model of ethnicity' can be summarized as follows:
 - ***Ethnicity is a matter of cultural differentiation*** - although, to reiterate the main theme of social identity (Jenkins 2004), identification always involves a dialectical interplay between similarity and difference.
 - ***Ethnicity is centrally a matter of shared meanings*** - what we conventionally call 'culture' - but is also produced and reproduced during interaction.
 - ***Ethnicity is no more fixed or unchanging*** than the way of life of which it is an aspect, or the situations in which it is produced and reproduced.
 - ***Ethnicity, as an identification, is collective and individual***, externalized in social interaction and the categorization of others, and internalized in personal self-identification.
- 

ETHNIC GROUPS AND ETHNIC IDENTITY

- Some social anthropologists use to define ethnic groups basically based on **objective criteria**, others mainly depend on **subjective elements**, and still some others use a **mix of objective and subjective** ethnic elements.
- **Smith (1986)** defined ethnic groups as a named human population (a collective name) with myths of common ancestry/descent, shared historical memories, elements of common/shared culture, a link with a homeland (specific territory) and a sense of solidarity among at least some of its members.



- **Max Weber (1968)** defined ethnic groups as human groups that entertain a subjective belief in their common descent because of similarities of physical types or customs or both, or because of memories of colonization and migration (Weber 1968). Some ethnic groups may be marked by *shared culture*; some others may be defined by *shared religion*, language, and/or customs. Nonetheless every ethnic group tends to have notions of common ancestry justifying their unity.
- **For Isajiw (1992)**, ethnic group refers to either a community-type group of people who share the same culture or to descendants of such people who may not share this culture but who identify themselves with this ancestral group.



By considering the various definitions of ethnicity, Hutchinson and Smith (1996) identified six main features that are predominantly constituted in the definition of an ethnic group:

1. A common proper name, to identify and express the “essence” of the community;
 2. A myth of common ancestry that includes the idea of common origin in time and place and that gives an ethnic group a sense of fictive kinship;
 3. Shared historical memories, or better, shared memories of a common past or pasts, including heroes, events, and their commemoration;
 4. One or more elements of common culture, which need not be specified but normally, include religion, customs, and language;
 5. A link with a homeland, not necessarily its physical occupation by the ethnic group, only its symbolic attachment to the ancestral land, as with Diaspora peoples;
 6. A sense of solidarity on the part of at least some sections of the ethnic's population.
- 

ETHNIC IDENTITY

Ethnic identity is an affiliative construct, where an individual is viewed by themselves and by others as belonging to a particular ethnic or cultural group. An individual can choose to associate with a group especially if other choices are available (i.e., the person is of mixed ethnic or racial heritage). Affiliation can be influenced by ***racial, natal, symbolic, and cultural factors*** (Cheung, 1993).

Racial factors involve the use of physiognomic and physical characteristics, *natal factors* refer to "homeland" (ancestral home) or origins of individuals, their parents and kin, and *symbolic factors* include those factors that typify or exemplify an ethnic group (e.g., holidays, foods, clothing, artifacts, etc.). Symbolic ethnic identity usually implies that individuals choose their identity, however, to some extent the cultural elements of the ethnic or racial group have a modest influence on their behavior.



CONT...

- Ethnic identity can be defined as a manner in which persons, on account of their ethnic origin, locate themselves psychologically in relation to one or more social systems, and in which they perceive others as locating them in relation to those systems. By ethnic origin is meant either that a person has been socialized in an ethnic group or that his or her ancestors, real or symbolic, have been members of the group. The social systems may be one's ethnic community or society at large, or other ethnic communities and other societies or groups, or a combination of all these



- **External and internal aspects of ethnic identity.**
- External aspects refer to **observable behaviour**, both cultural and social, such as (1), speaking an ethnic language, practicing ethnic traditions, (2), participation in ethnic personal networks, such as family and friendships, (3), participation in ethnic institutional organizations, such as churches, schools, enterprises, media (4), participation in ethnic voluntary associations, such as clubs, 'societies,' youth organizations and (5) participation in functions sponsored by ethnic organizations such as picnics, concerts, public lectures, rallies, dances.
- The internal aspects of **ethnic identity refer to images, ideas, attitudes, and feelings**. We can distinguish at least three types of internal aspects of identity: (1) cognitive, (2) moral, and (3) affective.



- The **cognitive dimensions** of EI include the self image of the people towards their own ethnic group; and the knowledge of ethnic members about their heritage and historical past.
- The **moral dimension** of EI is basically associated with the feeling of group obligation in the form of the importance a person attaches to his/her group. Eg., of teaching the ethnic language to one's children, of helping members of the group in times of difficulty.
- The **affective dimension** of EI constitutes the feeling of attachment to one's group which can be manifested in the associative preference for members of one's group & the feeling of security and comfort with the cultural patterns of the group.
- Le (2009) also identified two forms of ethnic identity. The first is “**resurgent ethnic identity**” in which the traditional or ancestral identities reemerge through historical events and particular circumstances.
- The other is “**emergent ethnic identity**” which involves the creation of new forms of group identity due to the convergence of particular circumstances. “More specifically, because of demographic changes or competition and conflict with other groups, a new ethnic identity based on group solidarity and similarity of experiences might form”.

RACE –THE SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF RACIAL IDENTITY

- Race is an elusive concept like ethnicity –used in a variety of contexts and meanings; sometimes interchangeably with ethnicity, where the relationship between the two concept remain complex. When first appeared, ethnicity/ethnic identity was used in synonym with race or racial identity, which complicated their relation. Moreover, the boundary between the two concepts is historically variable; what was 'racial' before 1945 may be more publicly acceptable as 'ethnic' today. Race/racial identity as a social construction of group categorization and identification, and come up with the significant distinctions among the races and the major difference between race/racial identity and ethnicity/ethnic identity.
 - Race is the idea that the human species is divided into distinct groups on the basis of inherited physical and behavioral difference.
 - Race generally refers to a group of people who have common some visible physical trait, such as skin colors, hair texture, facial features and eye formation.
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RACIAL CLASSIFICATION: A SHORT HISTORICAL OVERVIEW

- For some time, it was common to divide humanity into four main races, which recognized both on the scientific and folk notions of the concept. In this regard, race was used both as a system of human classification and social stratification as follows:
- ***Europeaeus***: White; muscular; hair – long, flowing; eyes blue – Acute, inventive, gentle, and governed by laws.
- ***Americanus***: Reddish; erect; hair – black, straight, thick; wide nostrils – Obstinate, merry, free, and regulated by custom.
- ***Asiaticus***: Sallow (yellow); hair black; eyes dark – Haughty, avaricious, severe, and ruled by opinions.
- ***Africanus***: Black; hair –black, frizzled; skin silky; nose flat; lips tumid – Crafty, indolent, negligent, and governed by caprice or the will of their masters.



- 'Race' is human groups defined by itself or others as distinct by virtue of perceived common physical characteristics that are held to be inherent. In this sense of the concept, race is a group of human beings socially defined on the basis of physical traits. At this level, concept of race would be important to the extent that it will inform people's actions; where it exists as a cultural construct, whether it has a "biological" reality or not.
- Racism, obviously, builds on the assumption that personality is somehow linked with hereditary characteristics, which differ systematically between "races", and in this way race may assume sociological importance even if it has no "objective" existence. Social scientists who study race relations need not themselves believe in the existence of race, since their object of study is the social and cultural relevance of the notion that race exists. Hence, in societies, where they are important, ideas of race may therefore, be studied as part of local discourses on ethnicity.
- 'Racial group' is a group of people, defined by itself or others as distinct by virtue of perceived common physical characteristics that are held to be inherent.

- Many scholars argued that while there is much overlap between race and ethnicity, they are distinct concepts that need to be distinguished. For example,
- **a) Max Weber (1922):** proposed that a *blood relationship* was necessary for racial identification but not for ethnic identification.
- **b) John Rex (1973):** explained that ethnicity is a wider classificatory or organizational principle than 'race'. In the case of ethnic groups, a far wider set of situations are based upon cultural differentiation of groups than those which are commonly called racial. But, few of ethnic groups have anything like the same conflictual consequences like racial situations do. That means, few ethnic conflicts are as bloody as 'racial' ones.



- **C) Gerald Berreman (1972, 1981):** viewed ethnicity as something linked in a dichotic relationship with race:
- *racial stratification/ categorizations* is associated with birth-ascribed status based on physical and cultural characteristics defined by outside groups.
- *ethnicity* is also ascribed at birth, but the ethnic group normally defines its cultural characteristics itself.
- Thus, racial categorizations are normally laced with inaccuracies and stereotypes, while ethnic classification is normally more accurate of a cultural group because it is defined by the group itself. Yet, ethnic classifications can also be defined and used by **outside groups** to stereotype an ethnic community in ways that are often oversimplified and that view ethnicity as a static cultural group. Some scholars claim that the external ethnic boundaries [i.e. the boundaries that are defined from the outside] are the source of racial distinctions and of race as a group phenomenon. That means, race is a response to external categorization and exclusion and whatever internal dynamics race generates, it is always a response to external exclusion rather than to internal identity generating forces.

THEORIES OF ETHNICITY: *PRIMORDIALISM, INSTRUMENTALISM AND SOCIAL CONSTRUCTIVISM*

Perspective	Description
Primordialist approach	Ethnicity is fixed at birth. Ethnic identification is based on deep, ‘primordial’ attachments to a group or culture.
Instrumentalist approach	Ethnicity, based on people’s “historical” and “symbolic” memory, is something created and used and exploited by leaders and others in the pragmatic pursuit of their own interests.
Constructivist approach	Ethnic identity is not something people “possess” but something they “construct” in specific social and historical contexts to further their own interests. It is therefore fluid and subjective.

THE PRIMORDIALIST PERSPECTIVE ON ETHNICITY & ETHNIC IDENTITY

- Primordialism is the idea that nations or ethnic identities are fixed, natural and ancient. They argued that individuals have a single ethnic identity which is not subject to change and which is exogenous to historical process.
- In the extreme case, ethnicity is treated as an extension of a pre modern social bond, an innate aspect of human identity, something that people are born with where attachment among ethnic members and its persistence is attributed to the ties of blood.



CONT...

- Another version of the primordial perspective primarily equates ethnicity with culture. An enduring character of ethnicity is viewed as the outcome of ***cultural and linguistic features***. Ethnicity is treated as something we are **socialized** into through which the cultural meanings related to ethnicity (e.g. language, history, and values) develops into durable tendencies and become self-evident frame of reference. This latter version of primordialism views cultural ties as indefinable with a deeper psychological effect on members of the group. In general, the primordial theory argues that there is something fundamental about the nature of ethnicity that ties individuals together and provides a sense of communal anchorage and protection lacking in other forms of organization.



- **Clifford Geertz** (1973): who systematized the primordial model articulated ethnicity as a ***natural phenomenon*** with its foundations in primordial ties deriving mainly from kinship, locality and culture. He recognizes the role of culture in defining the primordial '*givens*' that strength of such primordial bonds, and the types of them [i.e. primordial bonds] that are important differ from person to person, from society to society, and from time to time. What matters analytically is that ties of blood, language and culture are *seen by actors to be* indefinable and obligatory; that they are *seen as natural*. Geertz argues that in some respects these putative 'primordial attachments' are actually likely to be stimulated and quickened by the political modernization of nation-building. In its general sense then, it can be said that ethnicity is something given, ascribed at birth, deriving from the kin-and-clan-structure of human society, and hence something more or less fixed and permanent

○ **Anthony D. Smith** (1986) also theorized the defining elements of ethnic identification as *psychological and emotional*, emerging from a person's historical and cultural backgrounds. He illustrated that the 'core' of ethnicity resides in the myths, memories, values, symbols and the characteristic styles of particular historic configurations, i.e., what he calls 'a myth symbol complex'. The durability of the *ethnie* (ethnic group) resides in the forms and content of the myth-symbol complex. Of pivotal importance for the survival of the *ethnie* is the diffusion and transmission of the myth-symbol complex to its unit of population and its future generations. He emphasizes the "extraordinary persistence and resilience of ethnic ties and sentiments, once formed" and argues that they [ethnic ties and sentiments] are essentially primordial since they are received through ethnic socialization into one's *ethnie* and are more or less fixed. Smith (1986) regards primordial ties as the basic organizing principles and bonds of human association throughout history. He concluded that, 'primordialism' makes two distinct claims: firstly, ethnicity and ethnic attachment is "natural and innate", which would never change over time, and secondly, it is "ancient and perennial".

- The primordialist theory has been criticized for presenting a view of ethnicity and ethnic identity alternatively characterized as **static, fixed, involuntary, compelling, essentialized and naturalistic**. Although cultural traditions are shared, transmitted and internalized by people and are sources of internal cohesion and belongingness; they are not like “natural species” but dynamic and changing. The primordialist perspective is also inadequate to explain observed geographical variations in the expression of cultural identity by sub groups of people from the same ethnic origin. The primordial view is unable to adequately account for the observed flux in ethnic solidarity. It cannot account for ethnic change and dissolution, and the dynamics of ethno-genesis. The theory of primordialism also misses the fact that individuals’ attachments vary across situations, and identity shifts do occur. It is observed that in several cases where no “primordial ties” can be shown to have existed historically, ethnic mobilization has actually taken place as a result of socioeconomic and political factors.

THE INSTRUMENTALIST THEORY OF ETHNICITY & ETHNIC IDENTITY

- The instrumentalist theory views ethnicity as an *intentional or conscious strategy*, an adaptive response to the conditions governing the contest for acquisition of desired resources and a strategy to defend or seize resources. The reasons for a group asserting and maintaining an ethnic identity are said to be economic and political rather than psychological. Ethnic identification is encouraged by the pursuit of collective interests. The persistence of ethnicity is attributed to the functions it fulfills in terms of interest aggregation and group mobilization in pursuit of economic or political gain. When people can see no net usefulness in such group memberships, they will tend to attempt to disassociate themselves from it. The change in ethnic identity is explained in line with the cost-benefit calculations of individuals.

CONT..

- **Banks** (1996) explained the instrumentalist understandings of ethnicity as *an instrument of group mobilization for political and economic ends. Ethnicity is something that can be* hanged, constructed or even manipulated to gain specific political and/or economic ends. Proponents of instrumentalism advocate that bin the contexts of modern states, leaders (political elites) use and manipulate perceptions of ethnic identity to further their own ends and stay in power. Ethnicity is created in the dynamics of elite competition within the boundaries determined by political and economic realities” and ethnic groups are seen as a product of political myths, created and manipulated by culture elites in their pursuit of advantages and power.



- **Abner Cohen (1974)**, emphasizes on the ethnic group as a collectively organized strategy for the protection of economic and political interests. Ethnic groups share common interests, and in pursuit of these interests they develop “*basic organizational functions such as: distinctiveness or boundaries (ethnic identity); communication; authority structure; decision making procedure; ideology; and socialization*” .
- Abner Cohen’s perspective on ethnicity defines ethnic organization essentially as a kind of **political organization**. Ethnic ideology offers answers to the questions of *origins, destiny and, ultimately, the meaning of life*. However, Cohen argues that ethnicity must also have a practical function in order to be viable. He argued that ethnicity is an instrument for competition over scarce resources, which is nevertheless circumscribed by ideologies of shared culture, shared origins and metaphoric kinship. This may or may not be acknowledged by the agents themselves. Only by focusing on this aspect is it possible to explain why some ethnic groups thrive while others vanishes, and why only some ethnic identification assumes great social importance.

- Daniel Bell (1975) and Jeffrey Ross (1982) also emphasize the political advantage of ethnic membership choice. Ethnicity is "*a group option in which resources are mobilized for the purpose of pressuring the political system to allocate public goods for the benefit of the members of a self-differentiating collectivity*" (Ross, 1982).
- Rational choice and elite theories are examples of the instrumental perspective. Predicated on the 'theoretical primacy' of the individual, not the group, rational choice theory holds that *individual actors act rationally and in their own best interests*. It sees any action as determined by a rational motive and as the basis for the pursuit of scarce resources.



CONT...

- The instrumentalist theory underplays the emotional power and affective dimension of ethnic bonds. In its tendency to reduce ethnic phenomena to purely material motives the instrumentalist approach lack an adequate account of the emotive strength, and often apparently irrational power or pull associated with ethnic identities. The subjective import of ethnic group membership does not lie just simply in one's pursuit of practical interest, but also in one's feelings and a complex conception of identity. It has been shown that a number of ethnic categories reproduce their identity even if it actually reduces their chances of attaining prosperity and political power.



THE CONSTRUCTIVIST THEORY OF ETHNICITY AND ETHNIC IDENTITY

- The constructivist theory is an intermediate perspective. It recognizes that ethnicity cannot be simply taken as a given or conceptualized as an independent variable without also acknowledging its dependent status. Constructivism holds that ethnicity is ***constructed and that ethnic identities are not singular, nor are they fixed***; they may change over time and differ in their relative significance. Ethnicity is subject to fluctuation depending upon a group's solidarity and position in society. It is the circumstances that locate groups in particular situations and encourages them to define themselves in such a way that their interests are met. Therefore, ethnic identity has to be conceived of as a process, affected by history as well as contemporary circumstances, and by local as well as global dynamics. Ethnic identities are (re)constructed as narratives from the political–economic–cultural facts and fictions of history told in contemporary settings.
- *The central idea of constructivism is that ethnic groups are artificial and constructed rather than natural and eternal and they can be created, they can also be destroyed.*

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- Because the emphasis is on construction, this theory borrows a great deal from the instrumentalists' focus on specific contexts and circumstances whether they are economic or political, immediate, or structural. It explains ethnic group solidarity and the maintenance of ethnic group bonds underlining historical, structural and cultural contingencies and circumstantial aspects in ethnic relations. Ethnicity is viewed not as something that people possess as a property of a group but as aspects of relationships between groups and is constructed in certain situations.



Sit Six

**Customary and Local Governance
Systems and Peace Making**

Introduction

- Customary law is the set a set of custom, practices and beliefs that are accepted as obligatory rules of conduct by indigenous peoples and local community. it is the mechanism of resolving dispute. There is a procedure to resolve disputes without the assistance of the institutionalized justice system. *Customary law is unwritten law and kept in the memory of people or elders.* Therefore, when a case or dispute arises, the interested party have to ask these people for a solution. Custom is defines as a tradition or a usual way to behave. Custom is to society what law is to the state.
- A legal system is defined as a synergy of legal rules, legal principles, legal standards, legal policies, legal structures, legal tradition, legal actors, legal extension and legal penetration operating in a given geographical area.

Indigenous and local governance

- Governance is about the processes by which **public policy decisions** are made and implemented. It is the result of interactions, relationships and networks between the different sectors (government, public sector, private sector and civil society) and involves decisions, negotiation, and different power relations between stakeholders to determine who gets what, when and how. The relationships between government and different sectors of society determine how things are done, and how services are provided. Governance is therefore much more than government or 'good government' and shapes the way a service or set of services are planned, managed and regulated within a set of political, social and economic systems.
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- Local government is the essential institutional building block for local governance, the wider governance sphere comprises a set of state and non-state institutions, mechanisms and processes, through which public goods and services are delivered to citizens and through which citizens can articulate their interests and needs, mediate their differences and exercise their rights and obligations.
- The concepts of *local governance and decentralization*, at times used interchangeably, are related but different concepts. **Decentralization** is primarily a national political, legislative, institutional and fiscal process. While **local governance** can be affected by decentralization processes for example, if local governments are expected to provide services formerly offered through national organizations - it may or may not be accompanied by decentralization, representative or participatory democratic processes, transparency, accountability or other defining characteristics of 'good' local governance.

The Oromo Gadaa

The Gada system is a time-honored age and generation-set system practiced among the Oromo people who regarded the system as their common heritage and as one of their major identity makers. The gada is crucial organizing structure among the Oromo people and its social, political, ritual and legal aspects provides the framework for order and meaning of life. Gada organizes society via councils (yaa'aa), laws and injunctions, outlining rights and duties of its members. The Oromo recognized the Gada System as part of their cultural heritage and as a contemporary system of governance that functions in concert with the modern state system.

- In the Gadaa system, political power is transferred from one generation set (Luuba) to another every eight years. Gaada officials such as the Abba Gaada and Abba Seera(father of law) serve for eight years and leave their position to the new generation of Gadaa officials. The Gaada system involves a continuous process of law making and revision. The law making process has rooms for wider participation of the people. Gumi gaayo, a law making assembly of the Borana Oromo, is a good example. Gumi gaayo is held every eight years to revising, adapting, making and publicizing the customary law (seera) and custom (aadaa) of the Oromo. The Waliso Oromo have a law making assembly known as yaa'ii haraa, an equivalent of gumi gaayo, held every eight years.
- The Gaada is an indigenous system of governance, conflict resolution, and peacemaking. The indigenous system of governance among the Oromo also include institutions of conflict resolution such as the Jaarsa Biyyaa (literally: elders of the soil/land) institution.

Gadaa classes

Grade 1: Daballe from age 1-8 Dabale is the first of all grades and it is always occupied by a class of people sharing a common identity by virtue of the fact that they are all the sons of the gadaa class who are in power as leaders of Borana society as a whole. The dabballe stand out in Borana society because of their striking hairstyle, known as “guduru”.

Grade 2: Junior gamme (gamme didiko) from age 8-16 The transition ceremony by which the sons pass from the dabballe into gamme grade. The dabballes’ shave their hair and given names. In the gamme hairstyle, the hair is shaved in the middle, and the rest is allowed to grow long and cure with a regular treatment with better.

Grade 3: Kuusaa, junior warriors age 16-24 The game to kusa transition rites takes place at the shrine of Dhaddacha Dhera in the vicinity of Arero. At this place the father will shave the hair of his son/s. The transition rite thus came to an end and the “Kusa” proceeded with the Lallaba ceremony, the grand event in which the “election results” were announced to the assembled representatives of all Borana clans.

Grade 4: Raabaa age 25-32 At this stage the raba's tend to learn art of governance and this time is when they get married. The raba grade has mostly defense responsibility.

Grade 5: Doorii age 33-40 This Dori Grade is where males expected to have sons and could start procreating so as to soon acquire the aspired and respected status of fatherhood; with crucial responsible household-head. The Doroma; when they were planning to take power in the next Gada period. The remarkable stage where the Dori's gained arts of leadership and philosophy.

Grade 6: Gada age 41-48. Gada Grade is the stage of full political maturity and became the ruling party for the following eight years. This is the peak of social and political career of Gada and the optimum age of having maturity skill and capacity of holding and practically showing societal responsibilities.

Grade 7: Yuba age 49 and above. The Gada retires and becomes a Yuba elders ; the most important responsibility of retired Gada class (Yuubaa) is to oversee the ceremonial activities of the luba in power. The Yuba still takes over advisory functions and act as mediator, ritual experts and peacemakers.

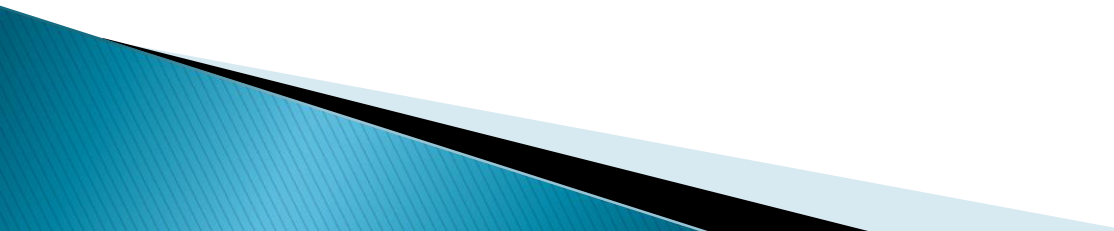
The Gedeo Baalle

- ▶ The Gedeo of southern Ethiopia have an indigenous system of governance called **Baalle**. The Baalle and the Gaada system of the Oromo have some similarities. For example, both have grading system and exercise periodic transfer of power (i.e., every eight years). The role of religion is high in the two indigenous systems of governance. Moreover, the customary law of the Gedeo is called **SEERA**. The Ya'a, the general assembly, is the highest body of the Gedeo indigenous system of governance. The Baalle is a complex system which has three administrative hierarchies: Abba Gada, Roga (traditional leader next the Abba Gada), and two levels of council of elders known as Hulla Hayyicha and Songo Hayyicha. The Abba Gada is the leader of the Baalle. The Baalle system has a body of laws called Seera. Conflicts are resolved by the Songo hayyicha at village level. When disputes are not settled at the village level, cases can be referred to first to the Hulla Hayyicha and finally to the Abba Gada. In general, the Gedeo system of governance has three major institutions: the ya'a (general assembly), the Seera (customary law), the Abba Gada, and council of elders.

Dere Woga of the Gamo

- ▶ The Gamo are among Omotic peoples of southern Ethiopia. Unlike their neighboring people such as Wolayta and Dawro, the Gamo did not have a centralized political system. The Gamo people were organized into several local administrations locally known as deres. According to anthropological findings, there were more than 40 deres across the Gamo highlands. Each dere had its own ka'o (king) and halaqa (elected leader). The indigenous system of governance embraces the dere woga (customary law) and the dubusha assemblies. The highest body of the indigenous governance is the dere dubusha, a general assembly that is responsible to make and revise customary laws, resolve major disputes that cannot be solved at the lower levels.

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- ▶ The dubushas assembly has three hierarchies: 1) the dere dubusha (at the top), sub-dere dubusha (at the middle), and guta/neighborhood dubusha (at the village level). Minor cases and disputes are resolved by the dere cima, council of elders. Like the Oromo Gada and the Gedeo Baalle, the indigenous governance of the Gamo is embedded in the Gamo belief system. It is believed that telling a lie and hiding the truth are considered as violation of taboo, which would lead to spiritual pollution and then misfortunes including lack of fertility, illness, and death of human beings and livestock.
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Intra and inter-ethnic conflict resolution institutions

- ▶ There are different indigenous institutions of conflict resolution and peacemaking across regions and cultures in Ethiopia. The following are some of them: *customary dispute resolution mechanisms; traditional mechanisms of conflict resolution; grassroots justice systems; and customary justice institutions*. Indigenous justice institutions and mechanisms share several common aspects including the following:
- ▶ High involvement of elders at different stages of conflict resolution and peacemaking process.
- ▶ Preference and respect for elders known for their qualities including experience in dispute resolution; knowledge of customary laws, procedures, norms and values of the society; impartiality, respect for rules and people; the ability of listening and speaking politely; honesty and tolerance.
- ▶ Indigenous dispute resolution practices focus on restoring social relationships, harmony, and peaceful coexistence.

- ▶ Indigenous justice systems also have differences in terms of hierarchies, procedures and level of complexities. For example,
- ▶ In some cultural settings, conflict resolution mechanisms involve several hierarchies and complicated procedures;
- ▶ The compositions and responsibilities of council of elders also vary from society to society. For example, different types of elders address different forms of disputes in some cultural settings; whereas the same body of elders deal with various types of disputes in other settings.
- ▶ Indigenous/customary justice institutions have been widely used across Ethiopian regions and cultures. With some exceptions, customary justice institutions include three major components. The three components are 1) **customary laws**, 2) **council of elders**, and 3) **customary courts or assemblies**.

- ▶ **Customary law:** it refers to a body of rules, norms, and a set of moral values that serve as a wider framework for human conduct and social interactions. The Sera of the Sidama, the dere woga of the Gamo, the Seera Addaa of the Oromo; Gordena Sera of Kestane Gurage are examples of customary laws. In most cases, customary laws are available orally. Some customary laws are published in recent years. For example, the Sebat Bet Gurage published their customary law named Kitcha: The Gurage Customary Law in 1998. Similarly, Kistane/Sodo Gurage have a written version of customary law known as Gordena Shengo.
- ▶ **Council of elders:** It is the second important institution of customary justice systems. The council of elders embraces highly respected and well-experienced community members who have a detail knowledge of the customary laws. Members of the elder's council are also known for their personal qualities such as truthfulness and experience in settling conflicts. Elders often serve their communities on voluntary basis without any payment. The number of the elders varies based on the nature of the case. The institution of council of elders has different names in various ethnic groups: Yehager Shimagile (Amhara), Jaarsaa Biyyaa (Oromo), Hayyicha (Gedeo), Guurtii (Somali), Dere Cima (Gamo), Deira Cimma (Wolayita), and Cimuma (Bari).

- ▶ **Customary courts** are public assemblies that serve two major purposes: (a) hearing, discussing and settling disputes, and (b) revising, adapting, and making laws.
- ▶ As noted above, in most cases, indigenous justice systems in Ethiopia embrace three major structures: customary laws, customary courts, and council of elders. Let us summarize the Gamo customary justice system to portray the three major structures. The customary justice system of the Gamo people of Southern Ethiopia has the following branches: 1) *Dere Woga*, customary laws, 2) *Dere Cima*, council of elders, and 3) *Dubusha*, customary courts or assemblies.

The three structures of Gamo customary justice system

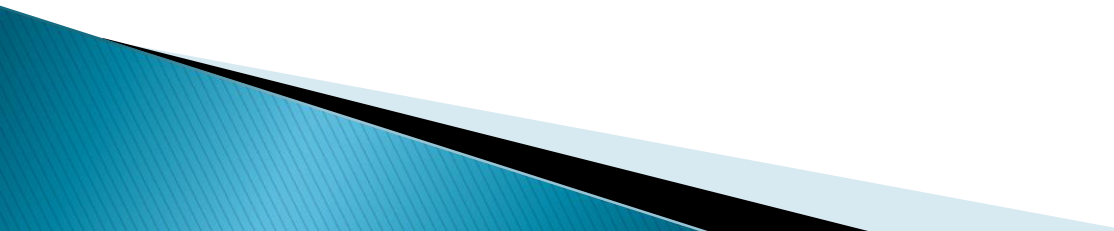
- ▶ **The Dere Woga:** It is a comprehensive body of rules and procedures that govern a wide range of issues including inheritance, property ownership, marriage and divorce, conflict resolution and gender division of labor.
 - ▶ **The Dere Cima:** Literally, dere cima means elders of the land/country. It includes notable and respected elders experienced in resolving disputes. Elders serving in dispute resolution are expected to have a sound knowledge of the customary laws, norms and values of the community.
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- ▶ **Dubusha:** it is customary courts. Dere dubusha, the biggest customary court in a given Gamo community, has two major functions: (a) hearing, discussing and resolving disputes, and (b) revising and making laws. In most Gamo communities, the structure of the customary courts has three levels: Guta dubusha, at the village level; sub-dere dubusha, at the kebele level; and dere dubusha at the higher level. Cases would be heard at the guta dubusha level, if not settled, referred to the second and third level of the structure. According to the indigenous belief, dere dubusha is a sacred place where supernatural power exists. It is a place where curses are uttered in its name; justice is delivered; and important assemblies are held. Dubushas are places where truth prevails. Misconducts such as telling a lie during dubusha assemblies are considered as transgression of taboos, which in turn would bring misfortunes to individuals and communities. Customary courts are easily accessible as each Gamo community has several customary courts

Strengths and limitations of customary justice systems/institutions

- ▶ Study findings indicate that indigenous institutions of dispute resolution have strengths and limitations. Some of their strengths and limitations are outlined below.
- ▶ ***Strengths of customary justice institutions***
- ▶ Incur limited cost in terms of time and resources/money; elders do not request payment for their services; fines and compensation are relatively small;
- ▶ Conflict resolution process are held in public spaces in the community; different parties (victims, offenders and community members) participate in the process; decisions are communicated in public;
- ▶ Decisions are easily enforced through community-based sanctions including social exclusion; compliance ensured through blessings and the threat of curses;
- ▶ Customary systems aimed at restoring community cohesion, social relations, collective spirit and social solidarity
- ▶ Rely on respect for elders, the tradition of forgiveness, transferring compensations, embedded in indigenous beliefs

Limitations of customary justice institutions

- ▶ Limitations related to protecting and safeguarding women's rights. Indigenous justice institutions are dominated by men. For example, the council of elders are not open to elderly women. Women are excluded from participation at customary courts and assemblies with a few exceptions.
 - ▶ Indigenous institutions of dispute resolution and peacemaking are effective to resolve dispute and restore peace within the same ethnic group. Their potential in resolving inter-ethnic conflicts and restoring long-lasting peace is very limited.
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Inter-ethnic conflict resolution

- ▶ Abbo Gereb is one of the indigenous institutions that address inter-ethnic conflicts. It is a dispute resolution institution in Rayya and Wajirat district, Southern Tigray. Abbo Gereb, literally means the father of the river Gerewo. Abbo Gereb serves to settle disputes between individuals or groups from highland Tigray and lowland Afar. Conflict between the two groups often arise because of dispute over grazing land or water resources, particularly in dry season. When conflict arises between parties from two ethnic groups, notable elders from Tigray and Afar come together to resolve the dispute and restore peaceful relations. Most of the elders involved in inter-ethnic conflict resolutions are bilingual: speaking Tigrigna and Afar.
- ▶ Ethnographic findings also reveal the existence of inter-ethnic conflict resolution mechanisms when conflicts arise between Afar, Issa, Tigrayans and Argobba. The mechanisms of inter-ethnic disputes have different names. It is called Xinto among the Afar, Edible among the Issa, Gereb among the Tigrayans, and Aboroge among the Amhara

Women's role in conflict resolution and peacemaking

▶ Women's peacemaking sticks

- ▶ Sidama women have two instruments of power: the **Yakka** and the **Siqqo**. The **Yakka** is women's association or unity group. The **Siqqo** is a **stick** that symbolizes peace and women honor. The **Siqqo** and the **Yakka** are closely associated. Mobilizing the **Yakka** and holding the **Siqqo**, Sidama women stand for their customary rights. They do this, for example, when a woman is beaten up by her husband or a pregnant woman is mistreated. For example, if a man prohibits his wife from **Yakka** participation, the women group impose a fine on him. The fine could be an ox. If a woman is ill-treated by her husband, the **Yakka** leader (known as **Qaritte**) mobilizes the **Yakka** and leads them to the house of the man. The husband would not have a choice when he is surrounded by the **Yakka** holding their **Siqqo** shouting and singing. If he is found guilty, the man would be forced to slaughter a sheep and give part of it to the **Yakka**. Sidama women also use their **Siqqo** to make peace between quarrelling parties. Oromo women also have a peace stick called **Sinqee**. **Sinqee** serves the purpose of protecting women's rights and making peace. Quarrelling men stop fighting when a woman stands between them holding her **Sinqee**.

Don Kachel: Agnuak women peacemaking institution

- ▶ Women in many regions of Ethiopia play an important role in peacemaking. Agnuak women have a peacemaking institution known as Don Kachel. Literally, DonKachel means '*let us all live in peace*'. It involves a peace-making movement initiated by Jaye, a group of wise and elderly Agnuak women. The Jaye start a peace-making movement based on information gathered through women's networking. The Jaye gather information about potential conflicts from different sources, including gossips spread in the community. The Jaye quickly act upon receiving information about, for example, a heated argument that could lead to conflict and fighting. The Jaye call the disputing parties for a meeting to settle the dispute. A few neutral observers will also be invited to monitor the process of the meeting. After examining the arguments of the two parties, the Jaye give their verdict. The party that caused the conflict request for forgiveness in public and pay some compensation. A sheep or goat is slaughtered after the conflict resolved; the meat is cooked and shared by participants of the meeting. Finally the Jaye would announce the meeting is over, the problem resolved, using these words 'Now let us all live in peace together!' The practice of Don Kachel is currently being adopted by other ethnic groups including the Nuer, Mejenger, Opo, and Komo.

Women's institution of reconciliation: Raya-Azebo, Tigray

► Elderly and highly respected women in a village in Raya-Azebo, Tigray established a reconciliation institution called the Debarte. The Debarte plays an important role in avoiding harms associated with the culture of revenge. A man may kill another man in a fight. The incident would trigger the feeling of revenge among male relatives of the murdered man. In such a tense situation, the wife of the killer requests for the Debarte intervention. The Debarte quickly start their intervention to stop the act of revenge. The Debarte instruct the murderer's wife to gathering her female relatives together. The wife and her female relatives get ready wearing their netela upside down and covering their hair with black cloths to show their grief and regret. After these preparations, the Debarte lead the female relatives of the killer to the home of the murdered man. The women cry loudly while walking to their destination. As they come near to the home of the killed person, they utter the following words: 'Abyetye ezgio! Abyetye ezgio!' 'Oh God help us! God help us! Upon their arrival at the compound of the victim, the Debarte kneel down and cover their heads with the dust of the compound. They beg the relatives/family of the murdered man to give up revenge and consider forgiveness. Initially, the relatives may not respond to the request; however, they will change their mind and open the door to show their consent for reconciliation. After persuading the victim's relatives to give up revenge, the Debarte give the way for elders who start the peace-making process.

Legal pluralism: interrelations between customary, religious and state legal systems

- ▶ Legal pluralism is an important concept in disciplines that study legal issues. It refers to the *existence of two or more legal or justice systems* in a given society or country. Legal pluralism indicates the co-existence of multiple legal systems working side-by-side in the same society. Legal pluralism is evident in the Ethiopian context. Multiple legal institutions, including customary laws and courts, state laws and courts, and religious laws and courts (e.g., the Sharia Law) work side-by-side in most parts of the country. The FDRE Constitution provides ample space for religious and customary laws and courts to address personal and family cases. The following two Articles show this reality.
- ❖ In accordance with provisions to be specified by law, a law giving recognition to marriage concluded under systems of religious or customary laws may be enacted (Article 34(4)).
- ❖ Religious and customary courts that had state recognition and functioning prior to the adoption of the Constitution shall be organized on the basis of recognition accorded to them by the Constitution. (Article 78(5))
- ▶ Legal pluralism is a pervasive phenomenon in Ethiopia. This is because a single legal system does not have a capability to address all legal cases and maintaining peace and order.



Unit Seven

Indigenous Knowledge Systems (IKS) and Practices

Indigenous Knowledge Systems (IKS)

- IKS is defined as technical insight of wisdom gained and developed by people in a particular locality through years of careful observation and experimentation with the phenomena around them. IKS is not just a set of information that is in the minds of the people, which can be simply taped and applied. It is accessible by recall and practice. IKS is embodied in culture and is described as an integrated pattern of human knowledge, beliefs and behavior. It consists of language, ideas, beliefs, customs, taboos, codes, institutions, tools, techniques, artifacts, rituals, ceremonies, folklores and gender. This culture is passed down from one generation to the next generation and generally it provides a holistic view of how to use natural resources based on traditional ethical perspectives. Indigenous knowledge systems (IKS) refer to a body of empirical knowledge and beliefs handed down through generations of long-time inhabitants of a specific locale, by cultural transmission, about the relationship of living beings with each other and their environment.
- In sum, IKS refers to “ a total of knowledge and practices, whether explicit or implicit, used in the management of socioeconomic, ecological and spiritual facets of life, stored in the collective memory and communicated orally among members of the community and to the future generations [through, stories, myth, songs, etc]

Indigenous peoples, and Indigenous Knowledge

- **Local people:** local people are the inhabitants of a particular geographic location who have a culture and belief system, distinct from the international system of knowledge (e.g. the tribal, native, first or aboriginal people of an area).
- Indigenous people possess, practice and protect a total sum of knowledge and skills constitutive of their meaning, belief systems, livelihood constructions and expression that distinguish them from other groups
- Indigenous peoples includes close attachment to ancestral territories and the natural resources in them; presence of customary social and political institutions; economic systems primarily oriented to subsistence production; an indigenous language, often different from the predominant language; and self-identification and identification by others as members of a distinct cultural group



Elements of indigenous identity

- Living in tradition-based cultures,
- Having political autonomy prior to colonialism, and
- Seeking to preserve cultural integrity in the present.
- Recognize the role of land to indigenous peoples

Features indigenous peoples across the globe.

- Self- identification as Indigenous peoples at the individual level and accepted by the community as their member;
- Historical continuity with pre-colonial and/or pre-settler societies;
- Strong link to territories and surrounding natural resources;
- Distinct social, economic or political systems;
- Distinct language, culture and beliefs;
- Formation of non-dominant groups of society; and
- Resolve to maintain and reproduce their ancestral environments and systems as distinctive peoples and communities

Indigenous knowledge

- ***Indigenous knowledge:*** - can be defined as “A body of knowledge built up by a group of people through generations of living in close contact with nature. It refers to the unique, traditional and local knowledge existing within and developed around the specific conditions of women and men indigenous to a particular geographic area. Indigenous knowledge contrasts with the international knowledge system produced by universities, research institutions and private firms. It is related to the ways members of a given community define and categorize natural, ecological, social and economic situations according to their lives. Indigenous knowledge is the knowledge that is an indigenous (local) to a given community over generations of living in a particular environment.

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- Indigenous knowledge is also characterized as *dynamic and continuously adapted* to the changing conditions as well as passes from generations to generations. IK is stored in peoples' memories and activities and it is expressed in the form of stories, songs, folklore, proverbs, dances, myths, cultural values, beliefs, rituals, community laws, local language and taxonomy, agricultural practices, equipment, materials, plant species and animal breeds.
- Indigenous knowledge is *shared and communicated* orally by specific examples and through cultures. Indigenous forms of communications are vital to local level decision- making process and to the preservation, development and spread of IK, i.e., indigenous knowledge has broader meaning. Such knowledge evolves in the local environment so that it is specifically adapted to the requirements of local people and conditions. It is also creative and experimental, constantly incorporating outside influences and inside innovations to meet new conditions. Thus, it is usually a mistake to think of indigenous knowledge as „old-fashioned; „back-ward“, static“ or unchanging“

Special Features of Indigenous Knowledge

- **Local**, in that it is rooted in a particular community and situated within broader cultural traditions; it is a set of experiences generated by people living in those communities. Separating the technical from the non-technical, the rational from the non-rational could be problematic. Therefore, when transferred to other places, there is a potential risk of dislocating IK.
- **Tacit** knowledge and, therefore, not easily codifiable.
- **Transmitted orally**, or through imitation and demonstration. Codifying it may lead to the loss of some of its properties.
- **Experiential rather than theoretical knowledge**. Experience and trial and error, tested in the rigorous laboratory of survival of local communities constantly reinforce IK.
- **Learned through repetition**, which is a defining characteristic of tradition even when new knowledge is added. Repetition aids in the retention and reinforcement of IK.
- **Constantly changing**, being produced as well as reproduced, discovered as well as lost; though it is often perceived by external observers as being somewhat static

Significance of indigenous knowledge

- Indigenous knowledge is important in that people in a community value whatever resource they get from the environment through sustainable production systems. These communities are conscious of the need to self-reliant in capital stocks and management skills.
- The knowledge of local people is an enabling component of development. In this regard; a large percentage of the earth's genetic diversity has been maintained and managed through farmer's IKS.
- Indigenous knowledge system enable people to develop strategies for handling household and communal activities. For example in Ethiopia *Debo and Jige* are an important uniting forces in communal activities. Members of the community unite to provide essential inputs, including direct labor to operations. "This deployment of manpower is strongly supported by IKS, which is composed of technologies, rules, information, approaches, and relationships that are vital to sustainable development".
- IKS authorities (elders) make local rules to protect important resources such as useful plants, water bodies, stone terracing, agro-forestry, watersheds and rivers, food preservations, conflict management, calendar, fallowing as a soil regeneration practice, etc. According to Paula Puffer Paula (1995), indigenous / local knowledge can help find the best solution to a development challenges. For example, familiarity with local knowledge can help extensionists and researchers understand and communicate better with local people.

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- In general, indigenous knowledge is an important part of the lives of the poor. IK is a key element of the “social capital” of the poor; their main asset to invest in the struggle for survival, to produce food, to provide for shelter or to achieve control of their own lives. Furthermore, one cannot overlook indigenous knowledge’s ability to provide effective alternatives to Western know-how. IK offers local people and their development workers further options in designing new projects or addressing specific problems and wider disasters. Instead of relying on imported Western technologies, people in the developing nations can choose from readily available indigenous knowledge or, where appropriate, combine indigenous and Western technology

Indigenous knowledge and development

- Indigenous knowledge refers to what indigenous people know and do, and what they have known and done for generations practices that evolved through trial and error and proved flexible enough to cope with change.
- Indigenous knowledge passes from one generation to the next and enable indigenous people to survive, manage their natural resources and the ecosystems surrounding them like animals, plants, rivers, seas, natural environment, economic, cultural and political organization. Knowledge of these elements form a set of interacting units known as indigenous coping systems. In other words, "IK is relevant to development process such as agriculture, animal husbandry, traditional medicine, saving and credit, community development, poverty alleviation, and peaceful coexistence"

- Indigenous knowledge may help identify cost-effective and sustainable mechanisms for poverty alleviation that are locally manageable and meaningful. It increases and enhances livelihood options, revitalize agriculture, increase food security, improve health and promote a sense of cultural pride within the community. Many plants currently growing wild in the ancestral domain produce natural dye, fiber, detergent and natural oil. Several plants in the ancestral domain have medicinal uses. Chemical compounds of these plants could be identified for the production of organic medicine . "Indigenous knowledge is used at the local level by communities as the basis for decisions pertaining to food security, human and animal health, education, natural resources management, and other vital activities.
- indigenous institutions, indigenous technology, and low-cost approaches can increase the efficiency of development programs because IK is a locally owned and managed resource. Utilizing IK helps to increase the sustainability of development efforts because the IK integration process provides for mutual learning and adaptation, which in turn contributes to the empowerment of local communities.

Preservation, Challenges and Limitations of IK

- Indigenous knowledge, which has generally been passed from generation to generation by word of mouth, is in danger of being lost unless it is formally documented and preserved. The future of IK, that reflects many generations of experience and problem solving by thousands of indigenous people across the globe, is uncertain.
- The loss of IK would impoverish society because, just as the world needs genetic diversity of species, it needs diversity of knowledge systems. The rapid change in the way of life of local communities has largely accounted for the loss of IK. Younger generations underestimate the utility of IK systems because of the influence of modern technology and education.
- If IK is not recorded and preserved, it may be lost and remain inaccessible to other indigenous systems as well as to development workers. Development projects cannot offer sustainable solutions to local problems without integrating local knowledge.

Regarding the challenges and limitations of IK

- Although the knowledge of indigenous communities has been found to be very useful, the, exploitation of natural resources, and increased competition for employment, has set off a problematic chain of events. This modernization has influenced indigenous traditional spread of industrialization threatens the preservation and continued development of IK systems. Industrialization, along with its attendant processes of urbanization African which generate IK and practices can break down. Added to this is the commercial society in many ways and Ethiopia is no exception.
- IK can also be eroded by wider economic and social forces. Pressure on indigenous peoples to integrate with larger societies is often great and, as they become more integrated, the social structures pressure by multinational agrochemical companies eager to break into new markets. As Grenier (1998) puts it: “the growth of national and international markets, the imposition of educational and religious systems and the impact of various development processes are leading more and more to the “homogenization” of the world’s cultures. Consequently, indigenous beliefs, values, customs, know-how and practices may be altered and the resulting knowledge base incomplete.

Limitations

- IK is sometimes accepted uncritically because of naive notions that whatever indigenous people do is naturally in harmony with the environment. Thrupp (1989) argues that we should reject “romanticized and idealistic views of local knowledge and traditional societies”. There is historical and contemporary evidence that indigenous peoples have also committed environmental sins’ through over-grazing, over-hunting, or over-cultivation of the land. It is misleading to think of IK as always being ‘good’, ‘right’ or ‘sustainable’.
- Quite often the overlooked feature of IK, which needs to be taken into account, is that, like scientific knowledge, sometimes the knowledge which local people rely on is wrong or even harmful. Practices based on, for example, mistaken beliefs, faulty experimentation, or inaccurate information can be dangerous and may even be a barrier to improving the wellbeing of indigenous people.
- Doubleday (2003) pointed out that knowledge is power, so individuals are not always willing to share knowledge among themselves, or with outsiders. Knowledge is a source of status and income (as is the case, for example, with a herbalist) and is often jealously guarded. A related issue is that some indigenous peoples fear that their IK will be misused, and lacking the power to prevent such abuses, they choose to keep quiet.

The Erosion of Indigenous Knowledge Systems(IKS)

- **With rapid population growth**—often due to in-migration or government relocation schemes in the case of large development projects, such as dams — standards of living may be compromised. With poverty, opportunities for short-term gain are selected over environmentally sound local practices. With increasing levels of poverty, farmers, for example, may also have less time and fewer resources to sustain the dynamic nature of IK systems through their local experiments and innovations.
- **The introduction of market-oriented agricultural and forestry practices** focused on mono-cropping is associated with losses in IK and IK practices, through losses in biodiversity and cultural diversity. For instance, policies promoting generic rice and wheat varieties devalue locally adapted species. With the ready availability of many commercial foods, some biodiversity *seems to become less relevant, such as seed and crop varieties selected over the years for their long-term storage attributes.*
- In the short term, chemical inputs *seem to reduce the need to tailor varieties to difficult growing conditions, contributing to the demise of local varieties.*
- With deforestation, certain medicinal plants become more difficult to find (and the knowledge or culture associated with the plants also declines).

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- More and more knowledge is being lost as a result of the disruption of traditional channels of oral communication. Neither children nor adults spend as much time in their communities anymore (for example, some people travel to the city on a daily basis to go to school, to look for work, or to sell farm produce; many young people are no longer interested in, or do not have the opportunity for, learning traditional methods). It is harder for the older generation to transmit their knowledge to young people.
- As IK is transmitted orally, it is vulnerable to rapid change — especially when people are displaced or when young people acquire values and lifestyles different from those of their ancestors.
- Farmers traditionally maintained their indigenous crop varieties by keeping household seed stocks and by obtaining seed through traditional family and community networks and through exchanges with nearby communities. Some of these traditional networks have been disrupted or no longer exist.
- In the past, outsiders (for example, social, physical, and agricultural scientists, biologists, colonial powers) ignored or maligned IK, depicting it as primitive, simple, static, “not knowledge,” or folklore. This historic neglect (regardless of its cause — racism, ethnocentrism, or modernism, with its complete faith in the scientific method) has contributed to the decline of IK systems, through lack of use and application. This legacy is still continued, as a result of which many professionals are still skeptical.